

PROXY WARS

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Section 1: Conceptual Foundations

1.1 Definition of Proxy War

A **proxy war** is a form of indirect warfare in which major powers avoid fighting each other directly and instead support other parties - states or non-state actors - to advance their own strategic interests within a conflict. The defining feature is **substitution**: the visible combatants are not the true principals of the dispute.

QUOTATION

"A conflict where third parties are used as substitutes for fighting each other directly." - Andrew Mumford, *Proxy Warfare* (Polity Press, 2013)

"A proxy war is triangular - it needs a sponsor, a surrogate, and a target." - Daniel Byman, Brookings Institution

Proxy wars therefore mask the real antagonists behind the dynamics of a local conflict. What looks like a civil war, insurgency, or regional dispute is frequently fuelled, escalated, and sustained by external patrons pursuing larger geopolitical agendas.

1.2 Historical Background: Origins and Evolution

Understanding how the proxy-war model evolved is essential for CSS candidates, because each historical phase added a new layer to the concept that is still visible in 2026.

Cold War Crystallisation (1947–1991)

The term and the practice were crystallised by the nuclear standoff between the United States and the Soviet Union. Because direct war between two nuclear powers risked mutual annihilation, both superpowers competed by arming, training, and financing third parties - from Korea and Vietnam to Angola and Afghanistan. This period gave the concept its core logic: **escalation control through substitution**.

Cold War proxy-war theatres: Korea, Vietnam, Angola and Afghanistan



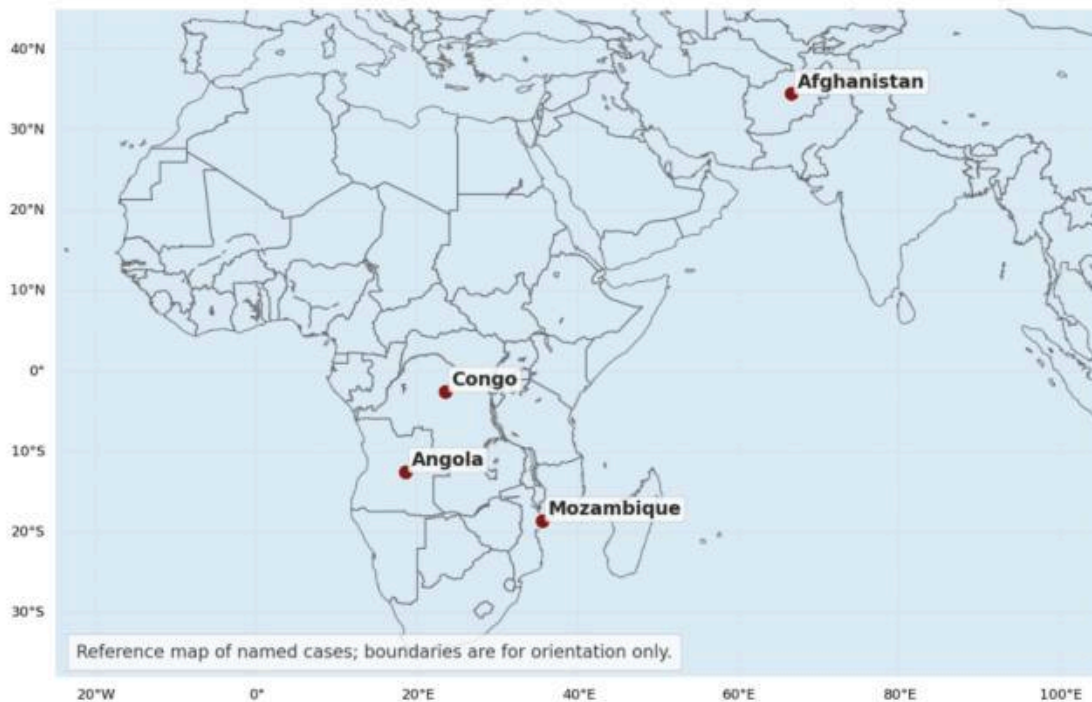
Map: Cold War proxy-war theatres: Korea, Vietnam, Angola and Afghanistan

Source: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

Decolonisation and the Third World Battlegrounds (1950s–1980s)

The collapse of European empires created dozens of fragile new states across Africa, Asia, and the Middle East. Superpowers exploited the resulting power vacuums, internal civil wars, and ethnic divisions to extend influence - turning local disputes (Congo, Angola, Mozambique) into internationalised proxy conflicts.

Decolonisation-era battlegrounds in Africa and Asia



Map: Decolonisation-era battlegrounds in Africa and Asia

Source: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

Post-Cold War Diffusion (1991–2001)

With bipolarity gone, proxy warfare did not disappear; it diffused. Regional powers (India, Pakistan, Iran, Saudi Arabia) began running their own proxy contests independent of Washington or Moscow, often over contested territory (Kashmir) or sectarian influence (the Gulf).

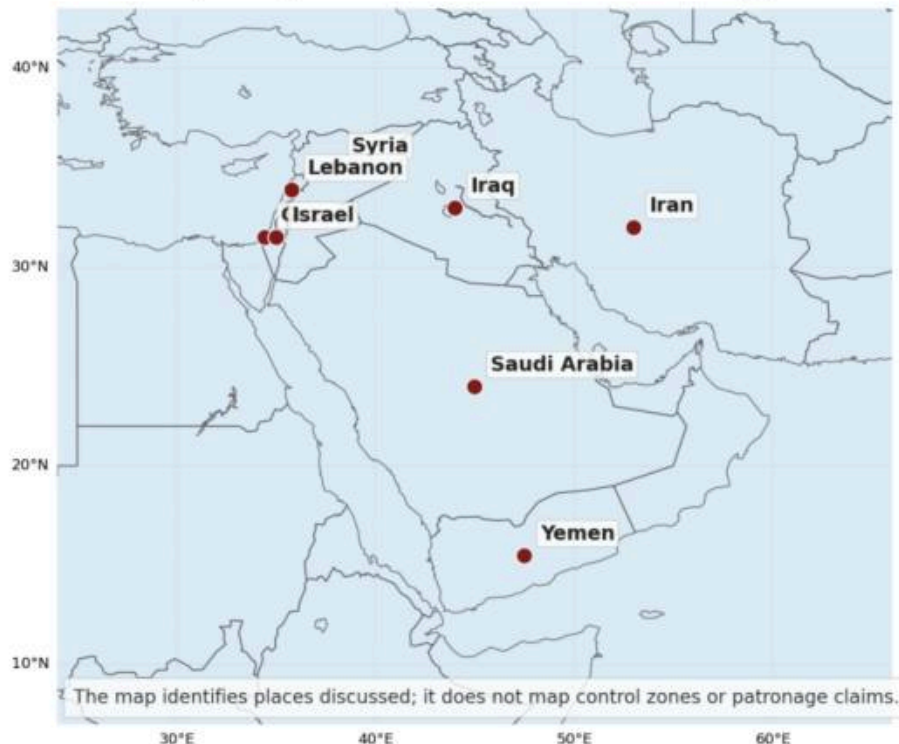
The War-on-Terror and Covert-Operations Phase (2001–2011)

Drone warfare, special-operations forces, and intelligence partnerships matured as tools of indirect statecraft, allowing patrons to shape outcomes with a far lighter and more deniable footprint than Cold War-era arms pipelines.

The Multipolar Phase (2011–present)

The Arab Spring's collapse into civil wars in Syria, Libya, and Yemen produced the most layered proxy environment in modern history, with multiple external patrons (US, Russia, Iran, Turkey, Saudi Arabia, UAE) backing competing factions simultaneously in the same battlespace. The **2026 US–Iran war and Pakistan's mediation of it (covered in Section 8)** mark a further evolution: proxy and inter-state dynamics now overlap so closely that a single state can simultaneously be a **target of cross-border proxy pressure** (Pakistan vis-à-vis the TTP and BLA) and an **indispensable broker-state** between two warring powers (Pakistan vis-à-vis the US and Iran) - a dual role with no close Cold War precedent.

Middle East proxy-war theatres and regional actors



Map: Middle East proxy-war theatres and regional actors

Source: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

1.3 Core Characteristics of Proxy Wars

i. Indirect Involvement of Major Powers

Great powers operate through proxies - forces they support but do not officially command - rather than risking direct confrontation, especially where nuclear deterrence is in play.

ii. Local Actors, Global Stakes

A conflict may appear local, but it is fuelled, escalated, and sustained by external actors pursuing larger geopolitical agendas.

QUOTATION

"Proxy wars mask the real antagonists behind local conflict dynamics." - Andrew Mumford, *Proxy Warfare and the Future of Conflict*

iii. Types of Support Provided

- Financial aid
- Weapons and military training
- Intelligence sharing
- Logistical support
- Political or diplomatic cover

This support strengthens local factions and prolongs conflict, often making peaceful resolution harder to achieve.

iv. Dual Structure of Conflict

Every proxy war involves **external actors** (the powers shaping outcomes from outside) and **local actors** (the ones physically fighting). Removing either element collapses the proxy-war classification into a simple civil war or a simple interstate war.

1.4 Requisite Criteria of a Proxy War

Scholars such as Andrew Mumford argue that at least four conditions must be jointly present before a conflict can be classified as a genuine proxy war.

Criterion	Description	Classic Example
Indirect involvement of external powers	Major powers avoid direct combat but shape outcomes through funding, weapons, or diplomacy	U.S. never deployed troops in Afghanistan, 1979–89
Use of local proxies or militias	Local fighters carry out combat on behalf of foreign patrons	Afghan Mujahideen trained and funded by the U.S. and Pakistan
Strategic objectives of patrons	External states pursue clear geopolitical, ideological, or security interests	U.S. objective: weaken the USSR and expand regional influence

Criterion	Description	Classic Example
Deniability and covert operations	Involvement is hidden or denied publicly even where evidence exists	CIA's Operation Cyclone routed through Pakistan's ISI

CSS Insight: Unless all four elements are jointly present, a conflict should not loosely be labelled a "proxy war" in an exam answer - examiners reward precision over rhetorical flourish. A civil war with foreign sympathy is not automatically a proxy war; a humanitarian intervention is not a proxy war merely because it serves donor interests.

1.5 Key Elements of a Proxy War

I. Primary External Actors

Powerful states that indirectly influence a conflict by backing local actors rather than participating directly, using military, financial, diplomatic, or covert tools to pursue strategic goals while avoiding direct engagement.

QUOTATION

"Proxy wars allow great powers to intervene in conflicts without the costs and risks of direct military involvement." - Andrew Mumford, *The RUSI Journal*

II. Proxies

Local or regional actors - militant groups, rebel organisations, or fragile governments - used to carry out conflict on behalf of external patrons, in exchange for funding, arms, or political legitimacy.

QUOTATION

"Proxies are the outsourced agents of war, and their loyalty is often transactional." - David Kilcullen, *The Accidental Guerrilla*

III. Support Mechanism

- Military equipment - weapons, explosives, vehicles, drones
- Financial aid - salaries, black-market funding, cryptocurrency channels
- Training - guerrilla warfare, sabotage, communications
- Intelligence - surveillance data, satellite imagery, internal leaks
- Political shielding - diplomatic cover in forums such as the UN

IV. Battleground State

The state or region where the conflict physically unfolds, usually weaker or strategically pivotal, and which absorbs the primary human and infrastructural cost while the patrons remain comparatively untouched.

Selected battleground-state theatres in proxy-war discussion



Map: Selected battleground-state theatres in proxy-war discussion

Source: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

QUOTATION

"In a proxy war, it is the battleground state that bleeds while the patrons remain untouched."
- Christopher Andrew, *The Secret World: A History of Intelligence*

V. Plausible Deniability

The capacity of external sponsors to deny involvement and so avoid diplomatic, legal, or military consequences - achieved through third-party arms routes, non-state intermediaries, and disinformation.

QUOTATION

"Plausible deniability is the oxygen of proxy warfare - it allows states to engage without accountability." - Andrew Mumford, *Proxy Warfare* (2013)

Section 2: Why States Wage Proxy Wars

2.1 Objectives of Proxy Wars

1. Avoiding Direct Confrontation Between Powerful States

Proxy wars allow nuclear-armed or otherwise powerful states to avoid clashes that could spiral into full-scale war, channelling rivalry through allies instead - as the U.S. and USSR did in Korea, Vietnam, and Afghanistan.

2. Projecting Influence Without Risking Soldiers or National Image

States extend influence in regions such as the Middle East or Africa by backing aligned groups without deploying large numbers of their own troops, avoiding domestic political backlash and reducing financial cost.

QUOTATION

"[Proxy wars] allow states to act without the scrutiny and accountability that conventional war attracts." - Andrew Mumford, *The Strategy of Proxy War*

3. Destabilising Rivals Covertly

A state may weaken a rival indirectly by backing insurgents or separatists inside the rival's territory or sphere of influence, generating internal instability without a formal declaration of war.

QUOTATION

"[States] use proxy warfare as a form of strategic sabotage to avoid accountability." - Patrick Porter, University of Birmingham

4. Testing New Weapons or Military Strategies

Proxy theatres function as real-world laboratories for drones, electronic jamming, and precision munitions, allowing states to refine doctrine without risking a wider war - as seen with multiple powers' drone and jamming trials inside Syria.

5. Supporting Ideological Allies

States back like-minded regimes or movements to spread an ideology and build alliances - a pattern especially visible during the Cold War's capitalist-communist divide and in the contemporary Saudi-Iran Sunni-Shia competition.

QUOTATION

"The Cold War's ideological battlegrounds were in the jungles, deserts, and hills of the Third World." - Odd Arne Westad, *The Global Cold War*

Summary Table: Objectives of Proxy Wars

Objective	Explanation	Example
Avoid direct confrontation	Avoid nuclear war by using third parties	Cold War (Korea, Vietnam)
Project regional influence	Expand geopolitical reach without direct combat	Iran–Saudi rivalry (Syria, Yemen)
Destabilise rivals covertly	Use proxies to weaken or distract rivals internally	U.S.–USSR in Afghanistan; India–Pakistan accusations
Test weapons and tactics	Trial new technology/strategy in real conditions	Drone warfare in Syria and Libya
Support ideological allies	Back friendly regimes or movements	USSR in Cuba; U.S. in Latin America

2.2 Reasons States Choose Proxy Warfare

a) Cost and Lack of Power-Projection Capacity

Resource-constrained states often cannot fight overseas wars directly; proxies offer influence without deploying national armies. The Carnegie Endowment has described Iran's reliance on regional militias as a way to compensate for its conventional military limitations.

Iran-linked regional proxy-war geography: Lebanon, Syria, Iraq and Yemen



Map: Iran-linked regional proxy-war geography: Lebanon, Syria, Iraq and Yemen

Source: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

b) Ideological Soulmates

Shared anti-colonial, communist, pan-Islamist, or anti-Western ideology makes proxy alliances appear natural and justified - as with Soviet support for Marxist movements in Angola, Ethiopia, and Afghanistan.

c) Enhancing Leadership Credibility at Home

Engagement in a foreign cause can rally domestic support and project assertive leadership - as with India's framing of its support for the Mukti Bahini in 1971 as both humanitarian duty and strategic necessity.

d) Limiting Escalation

Fighting through third parties lets rival states avoid formal war declarations, as in the Saudi-Iran rivalry conducted through Yemeni factions rather than direct confrontation.

e) Fear of Mutual Assured Destruction (MAD)

Nuclear deterrence locks rival powers into indirect competition because direct war risks catastrophic escalation - the central logic of the entire Cold War proxy system.

f) Lower Cost Than Conventional War

Train-and-equip missions deliver strategic impact at a fraction of the cost of deploying national militaries, as U.S. support for Syrian rebel factions illustrated relative to a full troop deployment.

g) Asymmetric Strategy

States unable to match a rival's conventional strength may use irregular proxies to offset that imbalance - a dynamic frequently cited regarding Pakistan's alleged historic support for Kashmiri militancy as a counter to India's conventional superiority.

h) Public Resistance to Direct War

Democracies with active media scrutiny often face resistance to overt war; covert or proxy channels bypass that scrutiny, as in the U.S. support for the Contras in Nicaragua during the 1980s.

Central America proxy-war geography: Nicaragua and neighbouring states



Map: Central America proxy-war geography: Nicaragua and neighbouring states

Source: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

i) Fear of International Reactions

Direct invasion risks UN, NATO, or global backlash; proxy warfare preserves deniability and lowers diplomatic cost, as with Russia's long-denied support for separatists in Eastern Ukraine since 2014.

Summary Table: Reasons Behind Proxy Wars

Reason	Core Idea	Example
Cost & lack of power projection	Low-cost conflict via third parties	Iran–Hezbollah
Ideological alignment	Supporting like-minded regimes/groups	USSR–Marxists in Africa/Asia
Boosting leadership image	Domestic popularity via foreign policy	India–Mukti Bahini
Avoiding escalation	Avoid formal wars through covert action	Saudi–Iran in Yemen
Nuclear deterrence	Nuclear powers avoid direct war	US–USSR in Vietnam, Afghanistan
Economic efficiency	Cheaper than national deployment	US in Syria
Asymmetric strategy	Weak states use proxies vs strong rivals	Pakistan–Kashmir (alleged)
Public opinion constraints	Democracies avoid unpopular	US–Contras in Nicaragua

Reason	Core Idea	Example
	wars	
Diplomatic deniability	Avoid sanctions/backlash	Russia–Ukraine

2.3 Four Structural Changes That Institutionalised Proxy Warfare

Drawing on Andrew Mumford (University of Nottingham), four historical transformations explain why proxy warfare became a routine instrument of statecraft rather than an occasional tactic.

1. Nuclear Deterrence and Fear of Escalation

Post-1945 nuclear weapons made direct superpower confrontation too dangerous, pushing rivalry into indirect channels such as Vietnam and Afghanistan.

QUOTATION

“The existence of nuclear weapons made proxy wars a means of avoiding apocalyptic confrontation between superpowers.” - Andrew Mumford, *Proxy Warfare*, 2013

2. Decolonisation and Civil Wars

Newly independent but unstable states across Africa, Asia, and the Middle East offered superpowers opportunities to internationalise local civil wars, as in Angola (1975–2002) and the Congo Crisis (1960–65).

3. Global Media and Public Opinion

Rising sensitivity to the human and political cost of overt war - sharpened after Vietnam - made covert or proxy support more politically palatable for democracies, evident in Syria and Libya since 2011.

4. Technological Advancement in Covert Operations

Surveillance, drones, cyber tools, and special-operations capabilities allow states to train, fund, and guide proxies while maintaining deniability, as seen in U.S. drone operations and Russian Wagner Group deployments.

QUOTATION

“Proxy warfare is now an institutionalised feature of international conflict.” - Andrew Mumford, *Proxy Warfare*, 2013

Summary Table

Transformation	Impact on Proxy Warfare
Nuclear deterrence	Made direct wars too risky; led to indirect engagements
Decolonisation	Created unstable states; superpowers intervened

Transformation	Impact on Proxy Warfare
	through proxies
Global media & opinion	Public resistance to direct war pushed states toward covert support
Technological advancement	Made discreet intervention possible; proxies became easier to manage

CSS EXAM TIP

When an exam question asks “**why do states prefer proxy wars to direct war?**”, structure the answer around three clusters: (i) **cost and risk reduction**, (ii) **escalation control under nuclear deterrence**, and (iii) **deniability and image management**. Anchor each cluster with one named example and, where possible, one attributed quotation.

Section 3: Success and Failure of Proxy Wars

Not every proxy war achieves the patron's objectives. Some efforts collapse quickly from poor planning, weak local legitimacy, or misaligned goals; others transform regions or topple regimes - often without a single soldier from the patron state fighting directly.

3.1 Factors That Make Proxy Wars Successful

1. Ideological Alignment Between Patron and Proxy

Shared worldview between sponsor and proxy strengthens coordination, trust, and long-term commitment - as with Soviet support for Marxist-Leninist movements in Angola, Ethiopia, and Vietnam.

QUOTATION

"Ideology offers a moral logic to the violence of proxy war." - Andrew Mumford, *Proxy Wars: The New Form of Warfare*, 2013

2. Local Legitimacy of the Proxy Group

A proxy embedded in local society - ethnic, tribal, or religious networks - can recruit, gather intelligence, and hold territory far more effectively than one seen as a foreign puppet, as with the Afghan Mujahideen's deep rural roots in the 1980s.

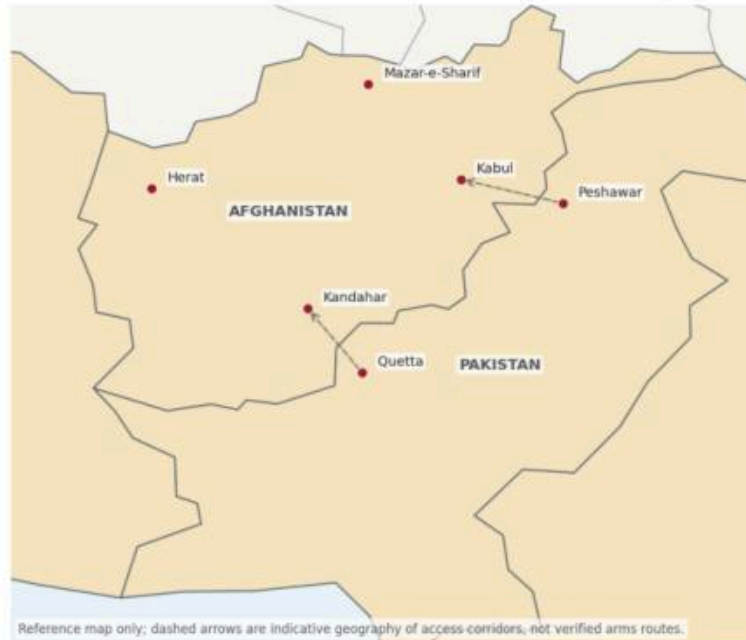
QUOTATION

"Foreign aid is effective only when insurgents have deep local roots." - David Kilcullen, *Counterinsurgency*, 2010

3. Sustainable Funding and Supply Chains

Continuous arms deliveries, safe havens, and financing are essential; proxies that lose supply lines are quickly overpowered. By the late 1980s, the CIA was reportedly spending over \$600 million a year on the Afghan resistance.

Afghan jihad supply-chain reference map: Pakistan-Afghanistan border belt



Map: Afghan jihad supply-chain reference map: Pakistan-Afghanistan border belt

Source: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

QUOTATION

"By the late 1980s, the CIA was spending over \$600 million a year on the Afghan resistance." - Steve Coll, *Ghost Wars*, 2004

4. Intelligence Superiority and Technological Edge

Advanced intelligence and weaponry can give even a small insurgent group a decisive battlefield edge - most famously the 1986 introduction of U.S. Stinger missiles, which neutralised Soviet helicopter dominance over Afghanistan.

5. Limited Intervention from the Global Community

Proxy wars thrive in "grey zones" where major powers avoid direct intervention and international law enforcement is weak, allowing local actors and their patrons relative freedom of action.

6. Weak State Capacity in the Target Region

Politically unstable, divided, or militarily incompetent target states allow proxies to fill the power vacuum quickly, as in Libya after the collapse of central authority in 2011.

QUOTATION

"When the state breaks, proxies flood in." - Frederic Wehrey, *The Burning Shores: Inside the Battle for the New Libya*, 2018

Case Study Summary: U.S. Proxy Success in Afghanistan (1980s)

- Strong local support for the Mujahideen

- Heavy ideological opposition to Soviet occupation (Islamic vs. Communist)
- Coordinated support from the U.S., Saudi Arabia, and Pakistan
- Technological advantage - Stinger missiles and secure communications
- Weak Soviet supply chains across hostile terrain
- No direct Western troop presence - escalation stayed contained

QUOTATION

"In the end, it was a \$600 million investment that helped bring down a superpower." - Steve Coll, *Ghost Wars*

Summary Table

Factor	Impact on Proxy Success
Ideological alignment	Builds trust and long-term coordination
Local legitimacy	Enables mass support and recruitment
Sustainable funding & supply	Keeps the proxy operational over time
Intelligence & tech superiority	Enhances efficiency and survivability
Limited global intervention	Allows action with fewer legal/diplomatic costs
Weak target-state capacity	Opens space for proxy takeover and legitimacy

CRITICAL ANALYSIS

The Mumford success-factor framework is useful but **not symmetrical**: it explains why a proxy *campaign* succeeds tactically, but says little about whether the **patron's strategic objective** is actually achieved. The Afghan jihad defeated Soviet forces, yet the same militant infrastructure later metastasised into the Taliban and al-Qaeda, working against the very patrons who built it. CSS candidates should flag this **boomerang effect** as a recurring weakness of proxy-war strategy: short-term tactical success can produce long-term strategic blowback for the sponsor.

Section 4: Effects of Proxy Wars

Proxy wars serve the geopolitical interests of external actors, but the real cost is paid by host nations, which suffer political, economic, social, and security damage that can persist for generations.

4.1 Political Effects

Proxy wars systematically weaken central governments and fragment authority, often leaving power vacuums.

- Collapse of state institutions
- Rise of tribalism, warlordism, and sectarian divisions
- Inability to implement coherent national policy
- Chronic political instability

Example: Afghanistan (Post-Soviet Withdrawal, 1989–1996)

After Soviet withdrawal, U.S.- and Pakistan-backed Mujahideen factions turned against one another, plunging the country into civil war and ultimately enabling the rise of the Taliban by 1996.

Afghanistan post-Soviet civil-war geography: key cities and border approaches



Map: Afghanistan post-Soviet civil-war geography: key cities and border approaches

Source: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

QUOTATION

"Afghanistan became a patchwork of warlord-controlled territories." - Ahmed Rashid, *Taliban: Militant Islam, Oil and Fundamentalism in Central Asia* (2000)

4.2 Security Effects

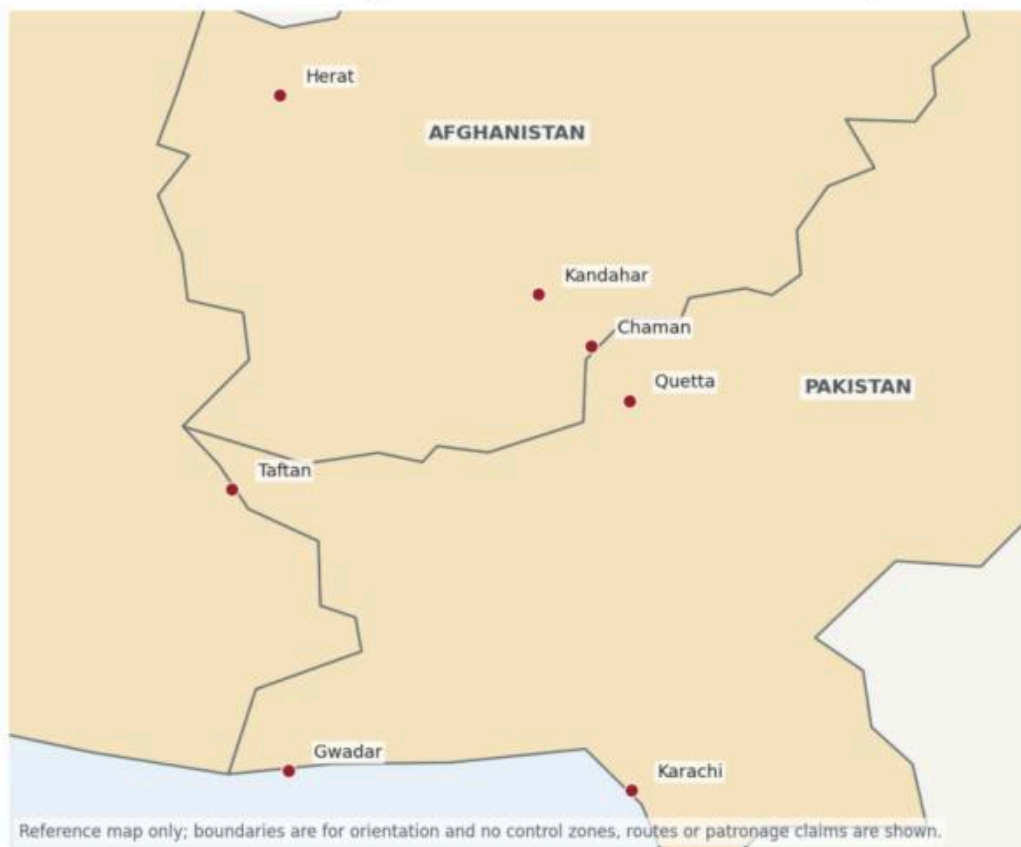
Proxy conflicts escalate regional insecurity by enabling the spread of arms, extremist ideologies, and cross-border instability.

- Proliferation of weapons and militias
- Increased terrorism and insurgency
- Spillover into neighbouring countries
- Mass displacement and refugee flows

Example: Balochistan and the Pakistan–Iran–Afghanistan Border Belt

Pakistan's Baloch separatist movement is alleged by Islamabad to receive external support, with Iran and Afghanistan both reporting spillover instability along their shared frontiers - a dynamic explored in depth in Section 7.

Pakistan-Iran-Afghanistan tri-border security belt



Map: Pakistan-Iran-Afghanistan tri-border security belt

Source: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

Other Case: Syrian Civil War

Proxy involvement by the U.S., Russia, Iran, and Turkey armed multiple factions, leaving the security situation in Syria fragmented for over a decade.

4.3 Economic Effects

Proxy wars cause severe economic destruction, cutting off trade, deterring investors, and decimating local industry.

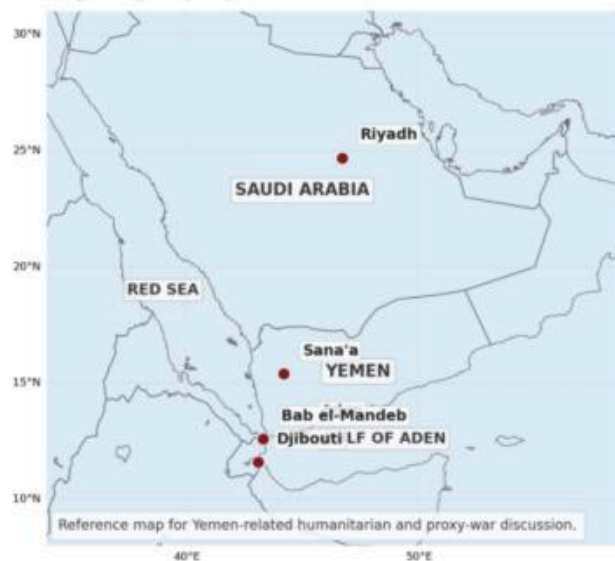
- Collapse of infrastructure - roads, schools, hospitals
- Flight of foreign investment
- Decline in GDP and productivity
- Growing reliance on international aid

FACT BOX | Syria

The United Nations Economic and Social Commission for Western Asia (UNESCWA) estimated the Syrian economy contracted by more than 70% between 2011 and 2020, with cumulative conflict-related losses estimated at \$442 billion and over half the population living in extreme poverty (UNESCWA, 2020).

In Yemen, the Saudi–Iranian proxy war has produced blockades, economic collapse, and famine conditions across large parts of the country.

Yemen proxy-war geography: Red Sea, Gulf of Aden and Saudi Arabia



Map: Yemen proxy-war geography: Red Sea, Gulf of Aden and Saudi Arabia

Source: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

4.4 Social and Humanitarian Effects

Proxy wars devastate societies by targeting civilians, collapsing public services, and eroding human capital across generations.

- Mass displacement of populations
- Widespread war crimes and human-rights violations
- Collapse of education and healthcare systems
- Loss of generational human capital

Humanitarian spillover theatres: Syria, Yemen and Afghanistan



Map: Humanitarian spillover theatres: Syria, Yemen and Afghanistan

Source: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

FACT BOX | Yemen

The UN Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (OCHA) has described Yemen's war as one of the world's worst humanitarian crises, with around 80% of the population requiring humanitarian assistance and over 2 million children suffering acute malnutrition (OCHA, 2023).

Section 5: Global Perspective - Contemporary Proxy Wars

Proxy warfare is a global strategic trend, not a regional anomaly - visible across fragile states, civil wars, and great-power rivalries. The following contemporary cases illustrate the model's continuing relevance.

5.1 Arab–Israeli Proxy Tensions

The rivalry between Israel and Iran has increasingly taken an indirect, proxy-based form. Iran supports Hezbollah in Lebanon and Hamas/Palestinian Islamic Jihad in Gaza, while Israel conducts airstrikes, targeted operations, and cyber operations such as the Stuxnet campaign developed with U.S. cooperation.

- Lebanon: Hezbollah's principal base of operations, especially in the south
- Gaza Strip: Hamas and PIJ receive Iranian financial and military support

Periodic wars (2006, 2014, 2021) between Israel and Iran-aligned proxies have repeatedly drawn civilian infrastructure and populations into the crossfire.

Arab-Israeli proxy-tension geography: Lebanon, Gaza, Israel and Iran



Map: Arab-Israeli proxy-tension geography: Lebanon, Gaza, Israel and Iran

Source: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

5.2 Syrian Civil War (Since 2011)

What began as an internal uprising against President Bashar al-Assad evolved into one of the most complex proxy wars of the 21st century, fragmenting Syrian territory into overlapping zones of foreign-backed control.

Syrian conflict geography: Syria and surrounding states



Map: Syrian conflict geography: Syria and surrounding states

Source: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

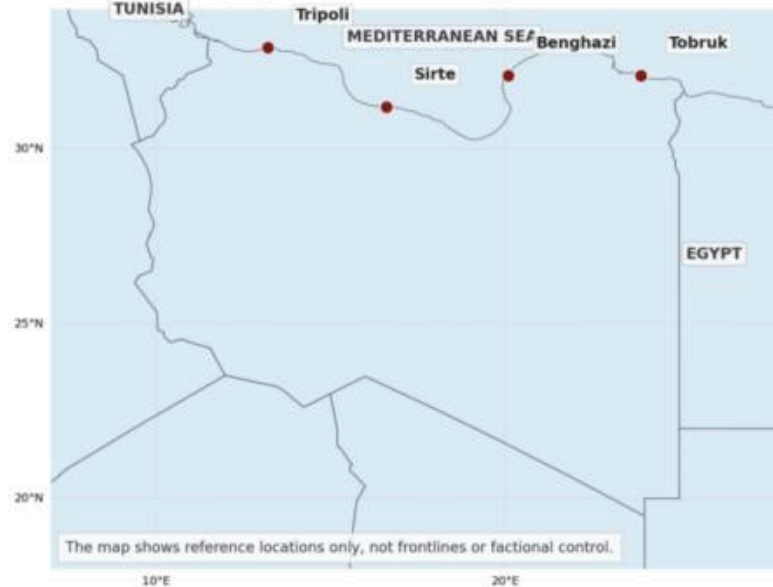
External Power	Proxy / Ally in Syria
United States	Syrian Democratic Forces (SDF), Free Syrian Army (FSA)
Russia	Syrian government forces, Wagner Group
Iran	Hezbollah, Iraqi and Afghan Shia militias
Turkiye	Syrian National Army (opposition groups)
Gulf States (KSA, UAE)	Anti-Assad rebel factions (initially)

The human cost has been immense: independent estimates and UN reporting place fatalities above 500,000 and displacement above 13 million, with infrastructure, economy, and governance devastated across the country.

5.3 Libya Conflict

Following the 2011 NATO-backed fall of Muammar Gaddafi, Libya descended into civil war, with competing governments and militias quickly drawing in foreign sponsors.

Libya conflict geography: Tripoli, Benghazi and the east-west split



Map: Libya conflict geography: Tripoli, Benghazi and the east-west split

Source: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

Patron State	Supported Side
UAE & Egypt	General Khalifa Haftar (Libyan National Army)
Turkiye & Qatar	Government of National Accord (GNA), Tripoli

Despite a UN arms embargo, weapons and foreign mercenaries continued flowing into the country, exacerbating the East–West split and leaving Libya's institutions weakened and divided.

QUOTATION

"Libya is the archetype of modern proxy war, with aerial, cyber, and mercenary dimensions all present." - International Crisis Group, 2020

5.4 Afghan Civil War (1990s–2021) and Beyond

Afghanistan has long been a site of external proxy warfare - from the 1980s anti-Soviet jihad, through the 1990s civil war, to the post-2001 NATO intervention and the post-2021 Taliban return.

Afghanistan proxy-war geography: Pakistan, Iran and Central Asia



Map: Afghanistan proxy-war geography: Pakistan, Iran and Central Asia

Source: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

- **1990s civil war:** Pakistan backed the Taliban; Iran and India supported the Northern Alliance under Ahmad Shah Massoud
- **Post-2001:** the United States and NATO backed the Afghan national government and army
- **Post-2021 withdrawal:** the Taliban returned to power; regional powers re-engaged to secure their own interests, and proxy dynamics continued through border militias

QUOTATION

"Afghanistan has been a laboratory of proxy warfare for over 40 years, with every major player sponsoring local warlords or insurgents." - Ahmed Rashid

Concluding Summary Table

Conflict	Proxies Involved	Major Sponsors	Outcome
Arab–Israel conflict	Hezbollah, Hamas	Iran, Israel	Cyclical violence, proxy escalation
Syrian Civil War	SDF, FSA, Hezbollah, ISIS remnants	U.S., Russia, Iran, Türkiye	Humanitarian disaster, fragmented state
Libya conflict	GNA vs. LNA, foreign mercenaries	Türkiye, UAE, Egypt, Russia	State collapse, divided governance
Afghan civil war	Taliban, Northern Alliance, warlords	U.S., Pakistan, Iran, India	Taliban resurgence, long-term instability

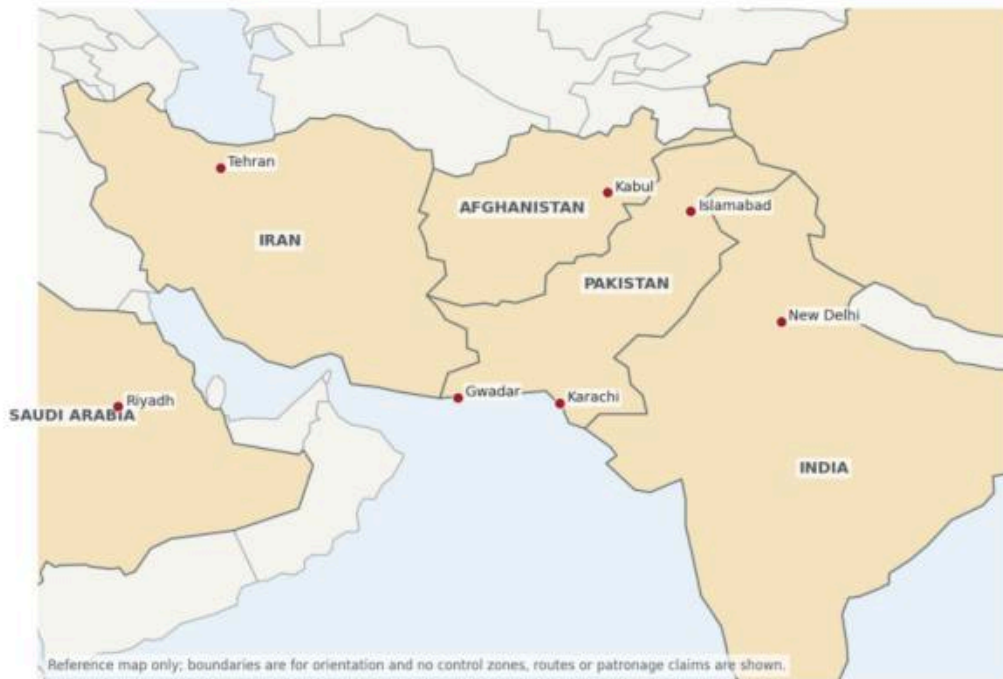
CONTEMPORARY RELEVANCE

Note the structural shift across these four cases: in Syria and Libya, **multiple patrons fought through proxies on the same soil simultaneously** - a more crowded, multipolar pattern than the bipolar Cold War model. This is the same multipolar logic that frames Pakistan's 2026 position between the United States, Iran, Saudi Arabia, and China (Section 8) - except that Pakistan inserts itself as **mediator** rather than as patron or proxy, a distinct third role increasingly relevant to 21st-century conflict management.

Section 6: Pakistan and Proxy Warfare - The Historical Dimension

Pakistan's geography - wedged between South Asia, the Middle East, and Central Asia - has made it both a **target** of external proxy pressure and, at different points, a **conduit** for proxy operations sponsored by others. Both dimensions remain analytically essential for CSS Pakistan Affairs.

Pakistan strategic crossroads: South Asia, Middle East and Central Asia



Map: Pakistan strategic crossroads: South Asia, Middle East and Central Asia

Source: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

6.1 East Pakistan Crisis (1971): India's Proxy Strategy

Before its formal military intervention in December 1971, India is widely held to have trained and supported the Mukti Bahini, a Bengali nationalist guerrilla force, in the lead-up to the creation of Bangladesh.

1971 geography: West Pakistan, India and East Pakistan



Map: 1971 geography: West Pakistan, India and East Pakistan

Source: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

Element	Detail
External patron	India
Proxy force	Mukti Bahini (Bengali separatist fighters)
Objective	Undermine West Pakistan; facilitate East Pakistan's separation
Support mechanism	Arms, training camps in Indian territory (e.g. Tripura), intelligence, media
Battleground	East Pakistan (now Bangladesh)

QUOTATION

"India intervened only after it had prepared the battleground through its proxies." - K. Subrahmanyam, Indian defence strategist, quoted in *Indian Express*, 2000

CSS Insight: This episode is among the clearest textbook examples of a local insurgency combined with foreign patronage escalating into full international conflict - and is treated by Pakistani scholarship as a foundational case of external subversion of state sovereignty.

6.2 Soviet Invasion of Afghanistan (1979–1989)

When the USSR invaded Afghanistan, the U.S. and Saudi Arabia used the Afghan Mujahideen as proxies, with Pakistan serving as the pivotal facilitator and launchpad for the operation.

Afghanistan proxy-war geography: Pakistan, Iran and Central Asia



Map: Afghanistan-Pakistan geography during the anti-Soviet proxy-war phase

Source: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

Element	Detail
External patrons	United States and Saudi Arabia
Proxy forces	Afghan Mujahideen
Support mechanism	CIA funding (Operation Cyclone), arms routed via ISI, religious mobilisation
Battleground	Afghanistan - strategy launched and supported from Pakistan

Effect on Pakistan: this episode produced lasting domestic consequences - the emergence of militant networks that later morphed into the Taliban and al-Qaeda, the spread of a “Kalashnikov culture” and drug-smuggling economy, and rising sectarianism and warlordism in the border belt.

QUOTATION

“The CIA’s support through Pakistan created a militant infrastructure that later turned against its creators.” - Steve Coll, *Ghost Wars* (2004)

6.3 Balochistan Insurgency (Since 2004)

The Baloch insurgency has roots stretching back to 1948 but reintensified after 2004. Pakistan alleges that India (through RAW) and, at various points, Afghan intelligence networks have provided external support to insurgent groups.

Element	Detail
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Element	Detail
External patrons	[Unverified] India (RAW); at times, Afghan intelligence networks
Proxy forces	BLA, BRA, BLF (Baloch separatist groups)
Objective	Destabilise Pakistan; disrupt CPEC and Gwadar Port development
Tactics used	Bombings, ambushes, propaganda (social media and diaspora networks)

Pakistan submitted dossiers to the UN in 2020 alleging Indian involvement, with the 2016 arrest of Kulbhushan Jadhav cited by Islamabad as central evidence. India has denied the allegations, and independent confirmation of state-level involvement remains contested in open sources. **[Unverified: claim disputed by India and not independently confirmed by neutral third parties.]**

Balochistan cross-border context: Iran, Afghanistan, India and Arabian Sea



Map: Balochistan cross-border context: Iran, Afghanistan, India and Arabian Sea

Source: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

QUOTATION

"Our dossier proves Indian involvement in Balochistan's unrest." - Pakistan Foreign Minister Shah Mehmood Qureshi, UN press conference, November 2020

6.4 FATA, the TTP, and the Alleged India–Afghanistan Nexus

Pakistan has long accused India of using Afghan territory as a launchpad to destabilise its western regions through covert operations and support for the TTP and Baloch separatists.

Pakistan western border belt: Afghanistan, Iran, KP and Balochistan



Map: Pakistan western border belt: Afghanistan, Iran, KP and Balochistan

Source: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

Element	Detail
External patron	[Unverified] India (RAW)
Proxy forces	TTP (Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan), BLA, BLF, and others
Battleground	Former FATA (now merged into Khyber Pakhtunkhwa), Balochistan
Support tactics	[Unverified] alleged financing, weapons recovery claims, intelligence links

QUOTATION

"We have irrefutable evidence of Indian state sponsorship of terrorism inside Pakistan." - DG ISPR Maj. Gen. Babar Iftikhar, 2020 press conference [denied by India; not independently validated by neutral third parties]

Summary Table: Proxy Wars and Pakistan (Historical)

Case	Patron(s)	Proxy Actor(s)	Objective
East Pakistan (1971)	India	Mukti Bahini	Break East Pakistan, create Bangladesh
Afghan War (1979–89)	U.S., Saudi Arabia	Mujahideen	Defeat USSR, contain communism
Balochistan insurgency	[Unverified] India, Afghan networks	BLA, BRA, BLF	Destabilise Pakistan, disrupt CPEC

Case	Patron(s)	Proxy Actor(s)	Objective
Covert ops in FATA	[Unverified] India	TTP, BLA, others	Create unrest, stretch security lines

Section 7: Analysis of Proxy War in Balochistan

7.1 Nature of the Conflict

Ethno-Nationalist Rebellion

The Balochistan insurgency is led by nationalist groups (BLA, BRA) demanding greater autonomy or outright independence, with roots in grievances over political marginalisation, control over natural resources, and perceived economic exploitation.

Low-Intensity Insurgency

Insurgent groups rely on guerrilla tactics - ambushes on security forces, sabotage of gas pipelines and railway lines, and attacks on Chinese nationals and CPEC-linked projects - aiming to bleed the state slowly rather than hold territory outright.

State Counter-Insurgency Response

Pakistan has deployed the Frontier Corps and other forces, combining targeted operations, intelligence work, and arrests; rights groups have frequently raised concerns over enforced disappearances and extrajudicial killings in this context.

QUOTATION

"The Baloch insurgency is rooted in political exclusion and uneven resource distribution." - Dr. Rasul Bakhsh Rais, Lahore University of Management Sciences (LUMS)

7.2 External Linkages

[Unverified: based substantially on official state allegations.]

Allegations of Indian Involvement (RAW)

Pakistan has repeatedly accused India's intelligence agency of supporting Baloch separatist groups. The 2016 arrest of Kulbhushan Jadhav, an Indian national, in Balochistan remains Islamabad's central evidentiary reference point; India disputes the characterisation and the claims are not independently verified by neutral parties.

QUOTATION

"We have irrefutable evidence of Indian interference in Balochistan." - Then-National Security Adviser Sartaj Aziz, 2016 [disputed by India; not independently verified]

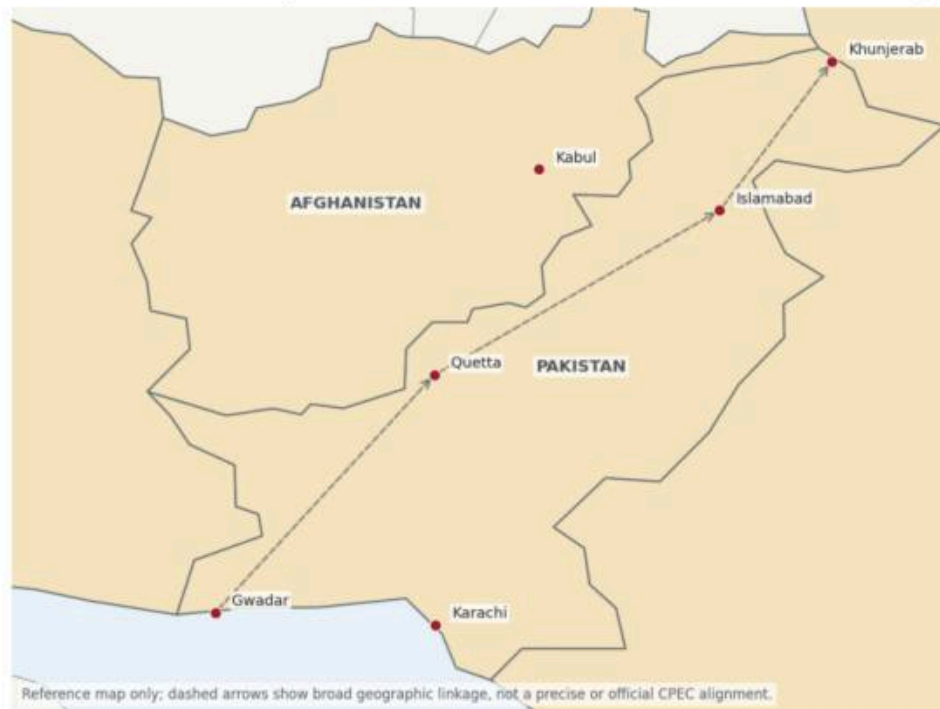
Cross-Border Safe Havens

Baloch insurgents are alleged to use border regions in Afghanistan for regrouping and tactical retreat, a concern that intensified before the Taliban's 2021 takeover and has persisted since.

CPEC as a Strategic Target

The China-Pakistan Economic Corridor, valued above USD 60 billion, runs through Balochistan, including Gwadar. Separatist groups argue the project marginalises local communities, and CPEC-linked infrastructure and Chinese personnel have repeatedly come under attack.

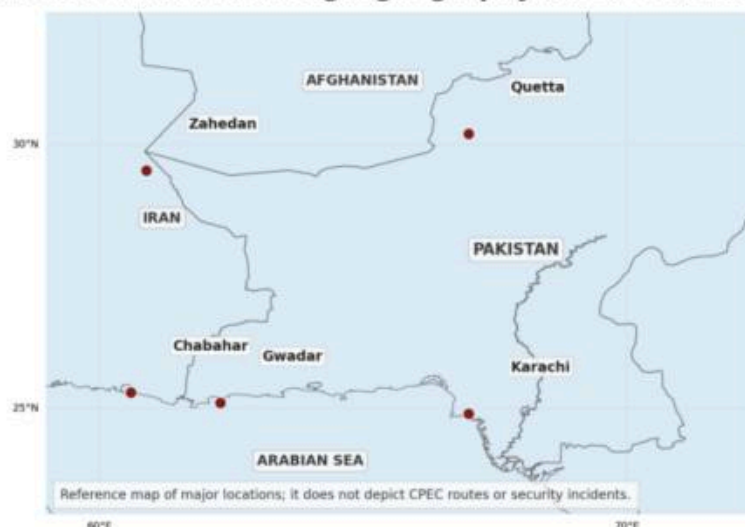
Gwadar-CPEC access points: Gwadar, Karachi, Quetta and Khunjerab



Map: Gwadar-CPEC access points: Gwadar, Karachi, Quetta and Khunjerab

Source: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

Balochistan and Gwadar: strategic geography for CPEC-linked discussions



Map: Balochistan and Gwadar strategic geography for CPEC-linked discussions

Source: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

QUOTATION

“CPEC symbolises state control over Balochistan and thus becomes a symbolic and strategic target for insurgents.” - International Crisis Group, Report No. 302, 2020

7.3 Impact on State and Society

Sovereignty Undermined

Persistent conflict reduces effective state control over large rural districts, and the state's reliance on military presence to maintain order signals a functional, if partial, compromise of full civilian sovereignty.

QUOTATION

“In any region where the state cannot exercise its writ without military presence, sovereignty is functionally compromised.” - Dr. Ayesha Siddiq, Security Analyst

Delayed Economic Development

Ongoing violence slows CPEC progress, discourages foreign investment, and strains government resources, with Gwadar port and associated road networks facing frequent security-related shutdowns.

Human Rights Concerns

Both sides face allegations of abuse: insurgents are accused of targeted killings of non-Baloch settlers, while security forces face allegations of enforced disappearances and extrajudicial killings of suspected militants.

QUOTATION

“Balochistan has become a black hole of information, where both rebels and the state violate human rights with impunity.” - Human Rights Watch, 2021

Militarisation of Civilian Space

Governance in many Baloch districts has effectively been handed to military or paramilitary authority, leaving civilian institutions in health, education, and local government underdeveloped and further alienating the population.

QUOTATION

“Balochistan is not just a domestic issue anymore; it's geopolitics.” - Dr. Ayesha Siddiq

Summary Table

Factor	Description
Nature of conflict	Ethno-nationalist rebellion using guerrilla tactics
State response	Counter-insurgency, FC deployment, intelligence

Factor	Description
	operations
External links	[Unverified] alleged RAW funding, Afghan sanctuaries, CPEC as flashpoint
Impact	Weakens sovereignty, delays development, escalates human-rights concerns

Section 8: Current Overview - Master Case Study

Pakistan, the United States, and Iran in 2026: From Proxy Battleground to Broker-State

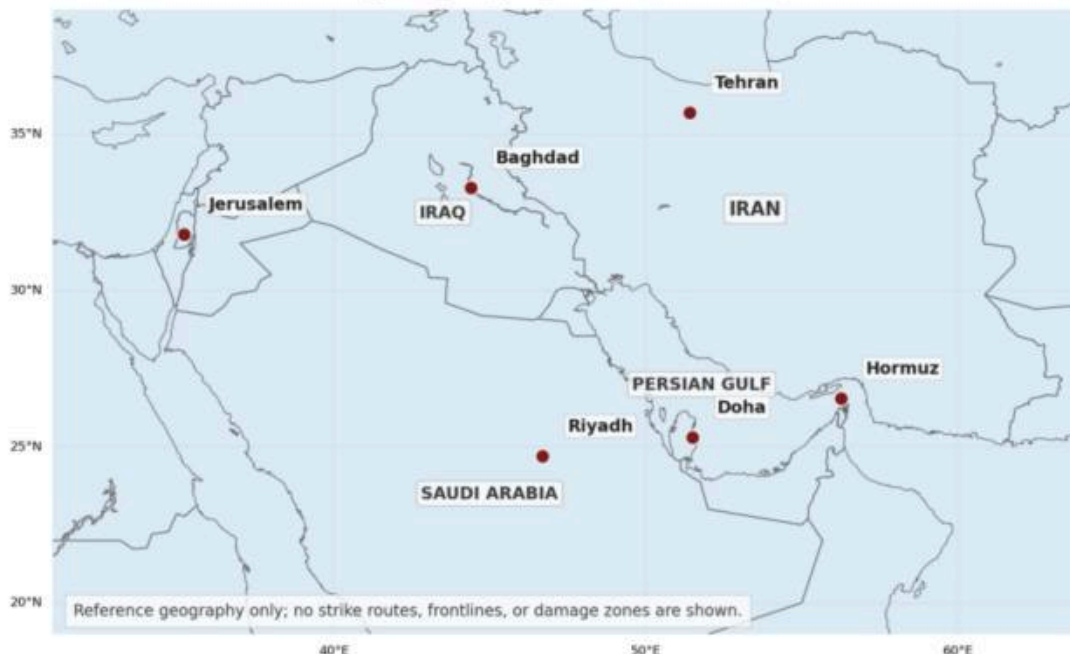
KEY IDEA

The 2026 US–Iran war and its resolution through the **Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding** (signed 17 June 2026) is the single most important live case study for connecting the theory of proxy warfare to Pakistan's current foreign policy. It demonstrates, in real time, **all five structural elements of proxy-war theory** (external actors, proxies, support mechanisms, a battleground state, and plausible deniability) while simultaneously showcasing a **new role** that classical proxy-war literature does not fully anticipate: Pakistan as **broker-state**, mediating between two warring principals rather than acting as either patron or proxy.

8.1 Background: The 2026 US–Israel–Iran War

On 28 February 2026, joint United States–Israeli airstrikes on Iran opened a new and far more intense phase of confrontation with Tehran, reportedly killing Iran's Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei along with other senior officials. Iran responded with missile and drone strikes on Israel and on Gulf states, including Saudi Arabia, partially closing the Strait of Hormuz to commercial shipping. The United States subsequently moved toward a naval blockade of Iranian ports to pressure Tehran further.

US-Israel-Iran war geography: Iran, Israel, Gulf and Hormuz



Map: US-Israel-Iran war geography: Iran, Israel, Gulf and Hormuz

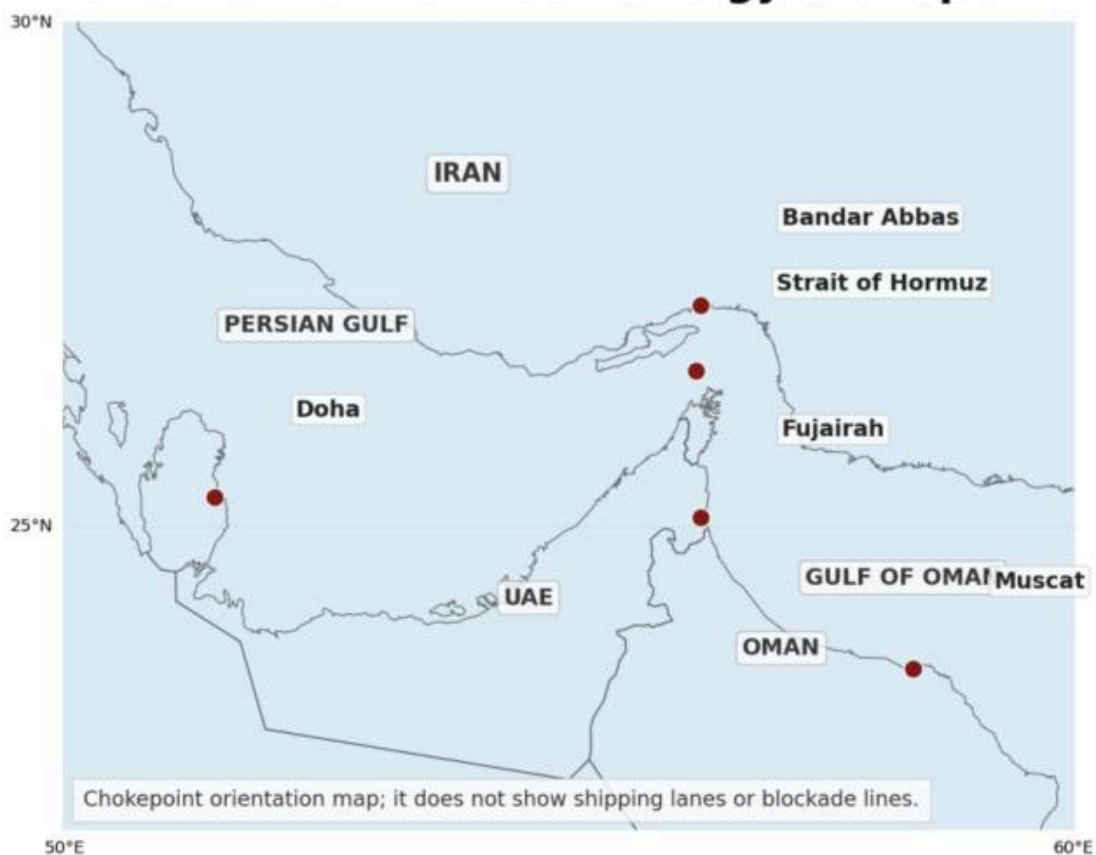
Source: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

The war is widely treated by international affairs commentary as an extension of the proxy and hybrid-conflict ecosystem analysed throughout this document: Iran's regional position has long rested on its network of allied non-state actors (Hezbollah, Iraqi and Yemeni militias, Hamas), and the 2026 war placed direct pressure on that entire "Axis of Resistance" architecture simultaneously with the conventional military campaign against Iran itself.

FACT BOX | Strait of Hormuz and Energy Stakes

Pakistan relies on the Gulf for roughly 90% of its oil imports, almost all of which transit the Strait of Hormuz - explaining why a partial closure of the Strait converted a distant Middle Eastern war into an immediate Pakistani economic and energy emergency.

Strait of Hormuz: Gulf energy chokepoint



Map: Strait of Hormuz: Gulf energy chokepoint

Source: U.S. Energy Information Administration, World Oil Transit Chokepoints -

https://www.eia.gov/international/analysis/special-topics/world_oil_transit_Chokepoints; base map:

Natural Earth - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

8.2 Pakistan's Twin-Front Dilemma: Mediating Abroad, Fighting at Home

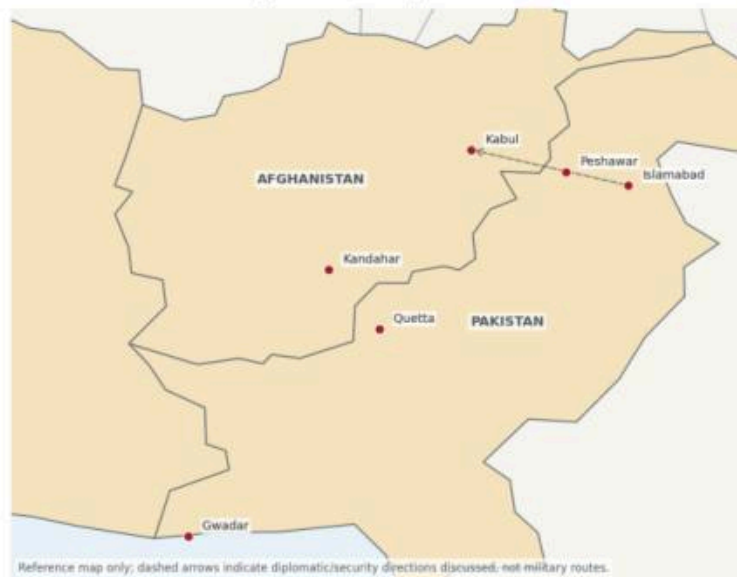
Pakistan's emergence as a mediator did not occur in a vacuum of domestic calm. Just one day before the Israeli–U.S. strikes on Iran, Pakistan had declared an "open war" against the Afghan Taliban (27 February 2026) and launched **Operation Ghazab lil-Haq**, a large-scale air-and-

ground campaign across the Durand Line in response to escalating Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) attacks that Islamabad says were facilitated from Afghan soil.

This created a genuinely unusual strategic position: Pakistan was simultaneously (i) a **combatant state** fighting an active cross-border war against Afghanistan, and (ii) the **primary diplomatic channel** trying to end a separate war between the United States and Iran on its western flank. Pakistani officials and outside analysts alike have noted that the intensity of Operation Ghazab lil-Haq was, at points, deliberately moderated so that Islamabad's diplomatic bandwidth and credibility could be devoted to the Iran mediation.

- Pakistan's Foreign Office maintained that Afghanistan bears “the burden of real process” by providing verifiable action against groups operating from its soil, even as Islamabad pursued the Iran-mediation track in parallel.
- A brief operational pause around Eid-ul-Fitr (18–23 March 2026), partly in response to de-escalation requests from Saudi Arabia, Qatar, and Turkiye, illustrated how Gulf-conflict diplomacy and the Afghan front were directly linked in Pakistani decision-making.
- Analysts have observed that Pakistan's diplomatic success in Islamabad coincided with continued, intense military operations against Afghanistan - including a 17 March strike on a drug-rehabilitation facility in Kabul that reportedly killed around 100 people, which drew Chinese calls for de-escalation.

Pakistan twin-front dilemma: Afghan border pressure and Iran mediation geography



Map: Pakistan twin-front dilemma: Afghan border pressure and Iran mediation geography

Source: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

CRITICAL ANALYSIS | Twin-Front Exposure

Master-level argument: classical proxy-war theory treats the external patron and the battleground state as distinct actors. Pakistan's 2026 position collapses that distinction - it is acting as an **external mediator-patron** in one theatre (Iran–US) while functioning as a **combatant battleground state** in an adjoining theatre (Afghanistan) that is itself shaped by alleged Indian and Afghan-intelligence proxy support to the TTP and BLA (see Section 6.4).

This is a genuinely new analytical category: the **dual-exposure middle power**, simultaneously projecting mediating influence outward while absorbing proxy pressure inward.

8.3 Pakistan's Declared Neutrality and the Logic Behind It

Pakistan's Ministry of Foreign Affairs adopted a policy of formal neutrality, condemning attacks on Iran by the United States and Israel while also condemning Iranian attacks on Gulf states such as Saudi Arabia. Pakistan was notably the only regional state to publicly condemn the initial US-Israeli strikes on Iran, even while avoiding direct criticism over the killing of Khamenei specifically.

Several interlocking interests explain this stance:

- **Energy security:** the near-closure of the Strait of Hormuz threatened roughly 90% of Pakistan's oil imports, forcing emergency austerity measures - a four-day federal/provincial workweek, a two-week closure of educational institutions, and restrictions on non-essential energy use.
- **Border security:** Pakistan shares a 900-kilometre border with Iran and feared spillover of conflict, refugee inflows, and sectarian violence (including threats attributed to groups such as the Zainabiyoun Brigade) into an already-volatile Balochistan.
- **Alliance management:** Pakistan signed a Mutual Strategic Defence Agreement with Saudi Arabia on 17 September 2025, under which aggression against either party is treated as aggression against both - without mandating automatic military intervention. This pact pulled Islamabad toward solidarity with Gulf states even as it sought to preserve its channel to Tehran.
- **Sectarian balance:** as home to the world's second-largest Shia population after Iran (commonly estimated between 15 and 20 percent of Pakistan's roughly 250 million people), Pakistan had a strong domestic incentive to avoid being seen as aligned against Iran.

The Pakistan Navy launched **Operation Muhafiz-ul-Bahr** on 9 March 2026 to protect Pakistani merchant shipping and energy-cargo vessels transiting Gulf waters, working alongside the Pakistan National Shipping Corporation.

Pakistan maritime energy-security geography: Arabian Sea and Gulf approaches



Map: Pakistan maritime energy-security geography: Arabian Sea and Gulf approaches

Source: U.S. Energy Information Administration, World Oil Transit Chokepoints -

https://www.eia.gov/international/analysis/special-topics/world_oil_transit_chokepoints; base map:

Natural Earth - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

8.4 Timeline: From the China–Pakistan Initiative to the Islamabad Memorandum

Date (2026)	Development
28 Feb	US–Israel strikes on Iran begin; Khamenei reportedly killed
27 Feb – 9 Mar	Pakistan declares “open war” on Afghanistan; Operation Ghazab lil-Haq launched
9 Mar	Pakistan Navy launches Operation Muhafiz-ul-Bahr to protect Gulf shipping
31 Mar	Pakistan and China jointly propose a five-point peace initiative
5–6 Apr	Pakistan circulates a 45-day two-phase ceasefire framework
8 Apr	US and Iran agree an initial two-week ceasefire, mediated by Pakistan
10–11 Apr	First round of Islamabad Talks; US delegation led by VP JD Vance, envoys Witkoff and Kushner; Iranian delegation led by Speaker Ghalibaf and FM Araghchi; Pakistani team led by PM Shehbaz Sharif, Field Marshal Asim Munir, and DPM/FM Ishaq Dar
12 Apr	Talks end without agreement; Vance departs; US threatens a naval blockade
21 Apr	Trump extends the ceasefire indefinitely after further diplomacy

Date (2026)	Development
Mid-to-late Apr	Second round of Islamabad-mediated engagement pursued amid Iranian hesitation over alleged US ceasefire violations
12 Jun	US and Iran reach agreement on a final negotiating text after a new 60-day ceasefire framework
17 Jun	Trump and Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian sign the Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding (remotely, from Versailles and Tehran), with Pakistan's prime minister co-signing as mediator

QUOTATION | On Pakistan's mediating role

"A messenger transmits, but Pakistan shaped the sequencing, timing and framing of proposals. It had leverage with all sides." - Ishtiaq Ahmad, professor emeritus of international relations, Quaid-i-Azam University, quoted in Al Jazeera, April 2026

Iranian Ambassador Reza Amiri Moghadam was reported as saying Tehran would conduct talks "in Pakistan and nowhere else, because we trust Pakistan." - reported by Al Jazeera, April 2026

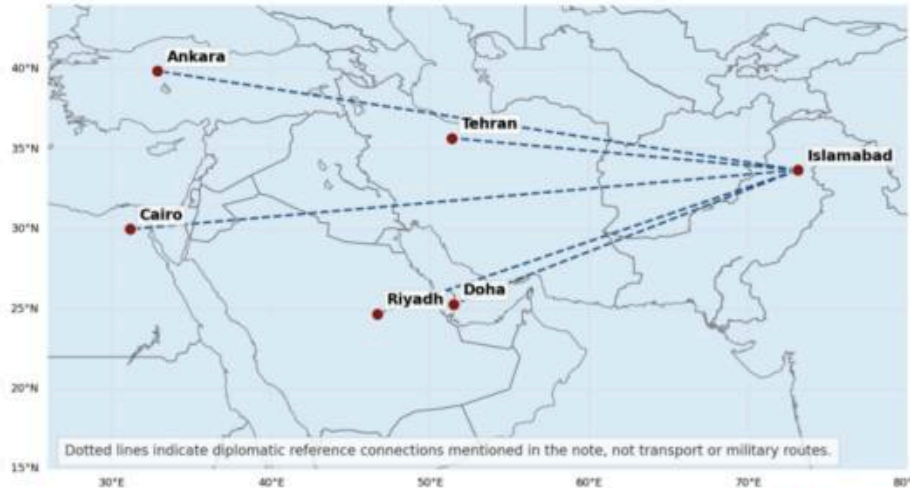
8.5 Why Pakistan? Explaining the Broker-State Role

Pakistan's selection as the principal channel between Washington and Tehran reflects a convergence of structural position and personalised diplomacy that is worth unpacking analytically for CSS purposes.

Structural Factors

- Pakistan maintains working relations with both Washington and Tehran simultaneously - a combination very few states can offer, since Pakistan does not recognise Israel and has not been drawn into the Abraham Accords framework.

Pakistan broker-state geography: Islamabad, Tehran and regional partners



Map: Pakistan broker-state geography: Islamabad, Tehran and regional partners

Source: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

- Pakistan's bureaucratic position is unusual: Islamabad represents Iranian diplomatic interests in Washington under existing arrangements, giving it institutional channels other mediators lack.
- Pakistan's parallel ties to Saudi Arabia, China, Turkiye, Egypt, and Qatar gave it a wide coalition of regional actors with a shared interest in de-escalation, several of whom (Saudi Arabia, Turkiye, Egypt) joined Pakistan in ministerial consultations in Islamabad in late March 2026.

Pakistan regional-partner diplomacy map: Gulf, Turkiye, Egypt and China



Map: Pakistan regional-partner diplomacy map: Gulf, Turkiye, Egypt and China

Source: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

- China's parallel diplomatic engagement - including a Pakistan–China five-point initiative and Deputy PM Ishaq Dar's visit to Beijing to meet Foreign Minister Wang Yi - reinforced Pakistan's position as a hub linking Western, Chinese, and Gulf diplomatic tracks.

Personalised / Relationship-Based Factors

- A close rapport between President Trump and Pakistan's Chief of Defence Forces, Field Marshal Asim Munir, built up over 2025 - including a White House lunch and an Oval

Office meeting on critical-minerals investment - gave Pakistan's military leadership an unusually direct line to the U.S. president.

- Pakistan's earlier role in the 2025 India–Pakistan ceasefire, and its subsequent (contested) nomination of Trump for the Nobel Peace Prize, had already established a pattern of high-profile, Trump-friendly Pakistani diplomacy.
- Personnel-level connections, including Pakistan's prior engagement with members of U.S. envoy Steve Witkoff's family on cryptocurrency-related matters, are cited by analysts as a secondary channel reinforcing trust.

CRITICAL ANALYSIS | Structural Power or Personalised Diplomacy?

Master-level argument for essay and current-affairs answers: a central analytical debate is whether Pakistan's 2026 broker-state role reflects a durable structural shift in its regional standing, or a **transactional, personality-dependent moment** built around the Trump–Munir relationship and unlikely to outlast either leader's tenure. Council on Foreign Relations analysis frames this explicitly as a remarkable reinvention for a state “viewed until recently...as a strategic destabiliser” (Chatham House, April 2026), while other commentary stresses Pakistan's own overreach - fighting an open war in Afghanistan even as it postures as a regional peacemaker - as a fragility that could just as quickly reverse the gain (European Policy Centre, April 2026).

8.6 The Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding (17 June 2026): Key Provisions

Formally titled the “Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding between the United States of America and the Islamic Republic of Iran,” the 14-point framework agreement was signed by President Trump and President Pezeshkian, with Pakistan's prime minister co-signing as mediator. It was originally expected to be signed in Switzerland but was instead signed two days early - by Trump at the Palace of Versailles following the G7 summit, and separately by Pezeshkian in Tehran.

- Termination of military operations on “all fronts, including Lebanon” - though Israel and the United States separately asserted that Lebanon was excluded from the ceasefire, a discrepancy Pakistan as mediator did not endorse.
- Toll-free reopening of the Strait of Hormuz to commercial shipping for an initial 60-day period.
- A phased end to the US naval blockade of Iranian ports.
- Termination of sanctions and the unfreezing of Iranian assets, with relief explicitly tied to Iranian compliance on the nuclear track.
- Iran's reaffirmation that it will not pursue nuclear weapons, with a “minimum methodology” of down-blending its enriched uranium stockpile under IAEA supervision to be agreed within the 60-day window.
- A prospective US-backed plan, alongside regional partners, for a \$300 billion reconstruction and economic-development fund for Iran, contingent on a final deal.

Iran reconstruction and regional-partner context



Map: Iran reconstruction and regional-partner context

Source: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

Crucially, the framework agreement left the hardest issues - the precise mechanism for Iran's uranium stockpile, and Iran's ballistic-missile programme and regional militia network - to be resolved during the 60-day negotiating window that followed signature, meaning the Memorandum is a ceasefire-and-framework document rather than a final peace treaty.

FACT BOX | The 14-Point Memorandum at a Glance

Signed: 17 June 2026, by President Trump (Versailles) and President Pezeshkian (Tehran), with Pakistan's prime minister co-signing as mediating party.

Core trade-off: Strait of Hormuz reopening and sanctions relief in exchange for an Iranian nuclear rollback and an end to hostilities on all fronts.

Mechanism: triggers a 60-day window for a final, UN-endorsed agreement; Trump stated that failure to comply would mean a return to military strikes.

8.7 Domestic Fault Lines: Sectarian Sensitivity and the Shia Question

Pakistan's mediating posture has had to be managed against a genuinely sensitive domestic backdrop. The killing of Ayatollah Khamenei triggered protests in several Pakistani cities,

including violent demonstrations in Karachi and unrest in the northern cities of Gilgit and Skardu, where curfews were reportedly imposed.

Pakistan domestic sensitivity map: cities mentioned in the note



Map: Pakistan domestic sensitivity map: cities mentioned in the note

Source: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

Field Marshal Asim Munir summoned Shia clerics for discussions amid these tensions; he was reported to have told an audience, in a pointed remark aimed at containing sectarian mobilisation, that those who "love Iran so much" should "go to Iran" - a comment that drew criticism from some Shia community figures even as it signalled the state's determination to prevent domestic spillover.

CRITICAL ANALYSIS | Sectarian Risk as a Structural Constraint

Master-level argument: Pakistan's Shia population is not a peripheral detail but a **structural constraint on foreign policy choice**. A state that is home to the world's second-largest Shia population after Iran cannot afford to be perceived domestically as facilitating an attack on Iran's leadership, regardless of its formal alliance commitments to Saudi Arabia. This sectarian sensitivity, layered onto an already-fragile Balochistan, gives Pakistan a built-in incentive toward strict, even-handed neutrality that goes beyond pure diplomatic strategy - it is also a tool of internal cohesion management.

8.8 Pakistan as Both Mediator and Alleged Proxy Battleground: The India–Afghanistan Angle

Even as Pakistan mediated between Washington and Tehran, Pakistani officials and commentary continued to frame the TTP and BLA as instruments of an alleged India–Afghanistan nexus working against Pakistani stability - a direct extension of the historical pattern documented in Section 6. Pakistani sources have specifically alleged that the Afghan Taliban administration and India's intelligence apparatus are jointly using Afghan soil as a base for a "twin-front" proxy

pressure campaign against Pakistan, even as Islamabad pursued its broker-state role in the Gulf theatre.

- **[Unverified, official Pakistani allegation]:** that RAW and Afghan-based networks have exploited Pakistan's preoccupation with the Iran-mediation effort to intensify proxy attacks inside Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and Balochistan during 2026.
- Independent reporting (the Middle East Institute, PRIO, Eurasianet) attributes the Pakistan–Afghanistan war primarily to the unresolved TTP sanctuary question rather than confirming third-country sponsorship, illustrating the gap between Pakistani official narrative and independently verified fact - a gap CSS candidates should explicitly flag rather than resolve in either direction.
- Commentators have also noted the irony that Pakistan's international image rehabilitation as an “indispensable broker” in the Gulf coincided with intensified, controversial military operations against Afghanistan, including strikes that reportedly killed significant numbers of civilians - a tension between Pakistan's external diplomatic narrative and its conduct on its western frontier.

QUOTATION | On the optics of dual roles

“Even as it mediates between Washington and Tehran, Pakistan has escalated its military campaign in Afghanistan, including strikes that reportedly killed hundreds at a drug rehabilitation hospital.” - European Policy Centre commentary, April 2026

8.9 Master-Level Analytical Arguments (For Essay and Current Affairs Answers)

1. **Reinvention versus fragility:** Pakistan's transformation from a state recently sanctioned and viewed in Washington as a “strategic destabiliser” (Foreign Policy, June 2026) into the indispensable channel for ending a major Middle Eastern war is a genuine reinvention of its international standing - but it rests on a narrow, personalised foundation (the Trump–Munir relationship, a handful of bureaucratic channels) rather than deep institutional leverage, making it potentially reversible.
2. **The dual-exposure paradox:** Pakistan is simultaneously the **broker** of an external great-power conflict and the **alleged target** of proxy subversion in its own western periphery (Section 8.8). This dual exposure is a distinctive feature of contemporary middle-power statecraft: influence and vulnerability now arise from the same set of geographic and relational facts - Pakistan's borders with Iran, Afghanistan, and its ties to the Gulf and China.
3. **Neutrality as strategic asset, not passivity:** unlike India's more cautious posture - publicly defended by External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar's remark that “India is not a dalal [broker/middleman] nation” (reported by the European Policy Centre, April 2026) - Pakistan's proactive, even-handed engagement with both Washington and Tehran shows that **calculated neutrality, actively marketed, can generate diplomatic capital** that passive non-alignment cannot.
4. **Economic vulnerability as a diplomatic driver:** Pakistan's dependence on Gulf energy routes (approximately 90% of oil imports via Hormuz) and Gulf remittance flows converted a distant war into a direct economic emergency, illustrating how **economic**

interdependence, not just security calculation, now drives middle-power diplomatic activism.

5. **Limits of the framework agreement:** the Islamabad Memorandum resolves the most visible flashpoints (Hormuz, sanctions, the ceasefire) but defers the hardest structural questions - Iran's missile programme, its regional militia network, and the precise uranium-stockpile mechanism - to a 60-day follow-on negotiation. CSS candidates should treat the Memorandum as a **ceasefire-with-framework**, not a comprehensive settlement, when assessing its durability.
6. **Comparative civil–military framing:** the prominence of Field Marshal Asim Munir alongside Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif throughout the mediation - leading the Pakistani delegation jointly with the elected prime minister and the foreign minister - reflects the continuing centrality of Pakistan's military leadership in shaping high-stakes foreign policy, a recurring theme for governance and civil–military relations questions in CSS Pakistan Affairs.

8.10 Risks and the Fragility of the Broker-State Moment

- **Overreach risk:** sustaining simultaneous engagement in the Afghan war, the Gulf mediation, and the Saudi defence commitment strains Pakistan's diplomatic and military bandwidth.
- **Economic fragility:** the Stimson Center has noted that Pakistan's relationship with the UAE was already strained by loan-repayment demands linked to the conflict, and that a collapse of the fragile ceasefire could make Pakistan's balancing act among the US, Iran, and Saudi Arabia "untenable."
- **Credibility risk:** Iran's periodic public denial of ongoing talks, even while privately continuing to engage through Pakistani channels, illustrates the structural fragility of a mediator role that depends on managing two parties' simultaneous public posturing and private diplomacy.
- **Dependence on personality:** the relationship-driven nature of Pakistan's leverage with Washington (centred on Trump and Munir specifically) raises the question of durability beyond the current U.S. administration.
- **Unresolved core issues:** because the Memorandum defers Iran's missile programme and its regional militia network entirely, a breakdown of the 60-day follow-on talks could reignite the war and expose the limits of Pakistan's mediating leverage.

CONTEMPORARY RELEVANCE | Why This Case Study Matters for CSS 2026–27

This case study should be the default reference point for any CSS Current Affairs, Pakistan Affairs, or International Relations question on **proxy wars, mediation, Pakistan's foreign policy reorientation, civil–military relations in foreign policy, or great-power competition in South/West Asia**. It demonstrates, with verifiable and recent facts, how Pakistan moved from being historically analysed mainly as a **proxy battleground and alleged proxy sponsor** (Sections 6–7) to being analysed as an **active broker-state** - while still carrying, simultaneously, the older vulnerabilities the rest of this document describes. A strong answer references both halves of that picture rather than treating Pakistan's new diplomatic prominence in isolation from its security and sectarian fragilities.

Section 9: CSS Relevance

Proxy warfare is a high-yield topic precisely because it sits at the intersection of several CSS papers. The following subheadings map the analytical angle examiners typically reward in each subject area.

9.1 Pakistan Affairs Relevance

- Pakistan's national narrative on Balochistan, the TTP, and the 1971 crisis is built substantially around the proxy-war frame - candidates must be able to present this narrative accurately while also flagging which claims are officially asserted versus independently verified.
- The 2026 Pakistan–Afghanistan war and the parallel Pakistan-mediated Islamabad Memorandum together form the most current and richest Pakistan Affairs case study connecting historical proxy-war patterns to live foreign-policy practice.
- Civil–military relations: Field Marshal Asim Munir's central role in the 2026 mediation effort, alongside the elected prime minister, is directly relevant to recurring CSS questions on the military's role in Pakistani foreign-policy formulation.

9.2 Current Affairs Relevance

- The 2026 US–Iran war, the Islamabad Talks, and the Islamabad Memorandum are likely to remain live current-affairs material through the 60-day follow-on negotiation window and beyond, given the unresolved nuclear and missile questions.
- Track how the ceasefire holds, whether the follow-on 60-day talks succeed, and how Pakistan's domestic and regional position evolves - current affairs preparation should be treated as a rolling update, not a fixed fact set.

9.3 Governance and Public Policy Relevance

- Proxy conflict zones such as Balochistan illustrate the governance challenge of projecting state authority into peripheral regions without further alienating local populations.
- Pakistan's emergency energy-austerity measures during the 2026 Gulf crisis (reduced workweek, school closures, fuel-use restrictions) are a case study in crisis governance under external economic shock.

9.4 Constitutional / Legal Relevance

- Article 40 of the Constitution of Pakistan commits the state to promoting Islamic solidarity, regional peace, and the peaceful settlement of international disputes - directly relevant to assessing Pakistan's 2026 mediating posture in constitutional terms.
- Plausible deniability and covert proxy support raise questions of state responsibility under international law, including possible violations of the UN Charter's non-intervention principle.

9.5 Economic Relevance

- The near-closure of the Strait of Hormuz in 2026 demonstrated how Pakistan's heavy dependence on Gulf energy imports (about 90% of oil) converts distant geopolitical shocks into immediate domestic economic crises.
- Proxy wars more broadly impose massive reconstruction and opportunity costs on battleground states - Syria's economy contracted by more than 70% between 2011 and 2020 (UNESCWA, 2020).

9.6 Social Relevance

- Sectarian sensitivity around the Shia community's response to the killing of Khamenei shows how international conflict can directly stress domestic social cohesion.
- Mass displacement, refugee flows, and human-rights violations are recurring social costs of proxy and hybrid warfare, from Yemen and Syria to Balochistan.

9.7 Security Relevance

- Operation Ghazab lil-Haq and Operation Muhafiz-ul-Bahr represent two simultaneous, distinct security responses - a land counter-terrorism campaign and a maritime energy-security operation - launched by Pakistan within weeks of each other in 2026.
- The TTP-BLA-Afghan-sanctuary nexus remains Pakistan's most persistent proxy-linked internal security threat.

9.8 Foreign Policy / International Relations Relevance

- Pakistan's 2026 mediation illustrates a third category of state behaviour in proxy-war theory beyond "patron" and "proxy": the **broker-state**, which uses cross-cutting relationships with rival powers to generate diplomatic capital.
- The episode is a strong illustration of middle-power diplomacy and bandwagoning theory, and of how personalised leader-to-leader relationships can substitute for institutional alliance structures in shaping outcomes.

9.9 Essay Relevance

- "Proxy wars: the new face of great-power competition"
- "Can small and middle powers profit from great-power rivalry? Pakistan's 2026 moment as a case study"
- "Sovereignty in the age of proxy warfare"
- "Neutrality as strategy: lessons from Pakistan's mediation between Washington and Tehran"

Section 10: Major Dimensions of the Topic

10.1 Political Dimension

- Fragmentation of authority and rise of warlordism in battleground states (Afghanistan, Libya, Syria)
- Domestic political leverage gained by patron-state leaders through foreign-policy assertiveness (India–1971; Pakistan–2026)
- Civil–military balance in shaping high-stakes mediation decisions (Pakistan, 2026)

10.2 Economic Dimension

- Direct costs: infrastructure destruction, GDP contraction, investment flight (Syria, Yemen)
- Indirect costs: energy-route disruption, remittance shocks, and austerity measures in adjacent states (Pakistan, 2026)
- Reconstruction economics as a bargaining chip in peace settlements (the proposed \$300 billion Iran reconstruction fund)

10.3 Social Dimension

- Displacement, refugee flows, and demographic strain on host and neighbouring states
- Sectarian and ethnic mobilisation risk when conflicts map onto religious or communal identity (Pakistan's Shia population and the Khamenei killing)
- Erosion of education and healthcare systems in conflict zones (Yemen, Syria)

10.4 Administrative Dimension

- Loss of state writ in peripheral regions (Balochistan, eastern Libya)
- Crisis administration under external shock (Pakistan's 2026 energy-austerity measures)
- Coordination challenges across multiple ministries and the military in fast-moving mediation diplomacy

10.5 Constitutional / Legal Dimension

- State responsibility and plausible deniability under international law
- Constitutional foreign-policy principles (Article 40, Constitution of Pakistan) versus the practical demands of alliance management
- The legal status of framework agreements such as the Islamabad Memorandum, which create binding-in-spirit but not fully ratified obligations pending a final deal

10.6 Security Dimension

- Proliferation of weapons, militias, and extremist networks in proxy theatres

- Twin-front security exposure, as Pakistan faced simultaneously in Afghanistan and along the Iranian border in 2026
- Maritime security and energy-route protection as an emerging dimension of proxy/hybrid conflict response (Operation Muhafiz-ul-Bahr)

10.7 Foreign Policy / Global Dimension

- Shift from bipolar Cold War patronage to multipolar, overlapping sponsorship (Syria, Libya)
- Emergence of the broker-state role as a distinct mode of middle-power engagement (Pakistan, 2026)
- Great-power competition (US, China, Russia) increasingly mediated through regional intermediaries rather than direct confrontation

10.8 Ideological / Religious Dimension

- Cold War capitalist–communist proxy alignment
- Contemporary Sunni–Shia regional competition (Saudi Arabia–Iran)
- Religious framing of military operations as a domestic legitimization tool (e.g. the naming and framing of Operation Ghazab lil-Haq)

10.9 Human Rights Dimension

- Civilian casualties from cross-border strikes (UNAMA-verified casualties in the Pakistan–Afghanistan conflict)
- Enforced disappearances and extrajudicial killings alleged on multiple sides in Balochistan
- Humanitarian catastrophe in protracted proxy theatres (Yemen, Syria)

10.10 Environmental / Technological Dimension

- Drone warfare, electronic jamming, and precision-strike technology trialled in proxy theatres (Syria, Libya)
- Infrastructure and environmental degradation from prolonged conflict (Syria's economic and physical destruction)
- Cyber operations as a deniable tool of indirect statecraft (Stuxnet)

10.11 Institutional / Governance Dimension

- Weak or contested institutions as a precondition for proxy penetration (Libya post-2011, Afghanistan post-1989)
- Strengthening judiciary, police, and intelligence coordination as a long-term defence against proxy subversion
- Regional and multilateral institutions (SAARC, SCO, OIC, FATF, UN) as underused tools for constraining proxy warfare

Section 11: Critical Analysis

11.1 Causes

- Nuclear deterrence and the resulting fear of direct great-power escalation
- Decolonisation-era state fragility creating exploitable power vacuums
- Sectarian and ideological rivalry providing ready-made alignment logic (Sunni–Shia, communist–capitalist)
- Domestic political incentives for patron-state leaders to appear assertive abroad

11.2 Impacts

- Prolonged, harder-to-resolve conflicts due to external sustenance of local factions
- Severe and disproportionate humanitarian, economic, and political costs borne by the battleground state
- Regional spillover - refugee flows, arms proliferation, extremist contagion
- Reputational transformation for skilled broker-states, as seen in Pakistan's 2026 repositioning

11.3 Challenges

- Distinguishing verified state involvement from unproven allegation (a recurring problem in Balochistan and FATA cases)
- Balancing domestic sectarian sensitivities against international alliance commitments (Pakistan's Shia population versus its Saudi defence pact)
- Sustaining mediating credibility while simultaneously fighting an active war on another front (Pakistan's twin-front 2026 dilemma)
- Weak international legal mechanisms for attributing and penalising proxy sponsorship

11.4 Opportunities

- Diplomatic capital and reputational gain available to states willing to play an active, even-handed broker role (Pakistan, 2026)
- Reconstruction financing as a tool to convert former battleground states into investment partners (the proposed \$300 billion Iran fund)
- Strengthened regional coordination mechanisms (the Pakistan–Saudi–Turkiye–Egypt quadrilateral track in 2026) as templates for future crisis management

11.5 Strengths (of the analytical/policy response)

- Pakistan's multi-vector relationships (US, China, Iran, Saudi Arabia, Turkiye) provided real diplomatic leverage rather than symbolic positioning

- Combined military and diplomatic toolkits (Ghazab lil-Haq and Muhafiz-ul-Bahr alongside the Islamabad Talks) reflect a degree of coordinated state capacity

11.6 Weaknesses

- Pakistan's mediating leverage is heavily personalised around specific leaders (Trump, Munir) rather than institutionalised
- Continuing reliance on unverified allegations (RAW/NDS sponsorship claims) weakens the evidentiary strength of Pakistan's own proxy-war narrative
- Economic fragility (Gulf remittance dependence, energy-import exposure) limits Pakistan's strategic autonomy even while it plays a high-profile diplomatic role

11.7 Policy Gaps

- No robust, depoliticised mechanism exists for independently verifying competing state allegations of proxy sponsorship (India–Pakistan; Iran–Gulf states)
- Weak linkage between Pakistan's external diplomatic gains and concrete economic dividends (trade concessions, investment) as of mid-2026
- Limited institutional follow-through to convert a single mediating success into a durable foreign-policy doctrine

11.8 Future Risks

- Collapse of the 60-day follow-on talks under the Islamabad Memorandum, which could reignite the wider war
- Renewed Pakistan–Afghanistan escalation diverting attention and resources from the Iran-mediation track
- Sectarian mobilisation inside Pakistan if regional tensions between Iran and the Gulf states resurface

Pakistan future-risk geography: western front, Gulf route and domestic cities

Map: Pakistan future-risk geography: western front, Gulf route and domestic cities

Source: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

- Overreliance on a single bilateral relationship (with the Trump administration) that may not persist beyond the current U.S. political cycle

Section 12: Contemporary Relevance

Proxy warfare is not a historical curiosity confined to Cold War textbooks; it is the operating logic behind several of the world's most consequential live crises as of mid-2026.

Global proxy-war pattern: selected contemporary theatres and chokepoints



Map: Global proxy-war pattern: selected contemporary theatres and chokepoints

Source: U.S. Energy Information Administration, World Oil Transit Chokepoints - https://www.eia.gov/international/analysis/special-topics/world_oil_transit_Chokepoints; base map: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

Multipolar proxy-war pattern: Syria, Libya, Yemen and Afghanistan



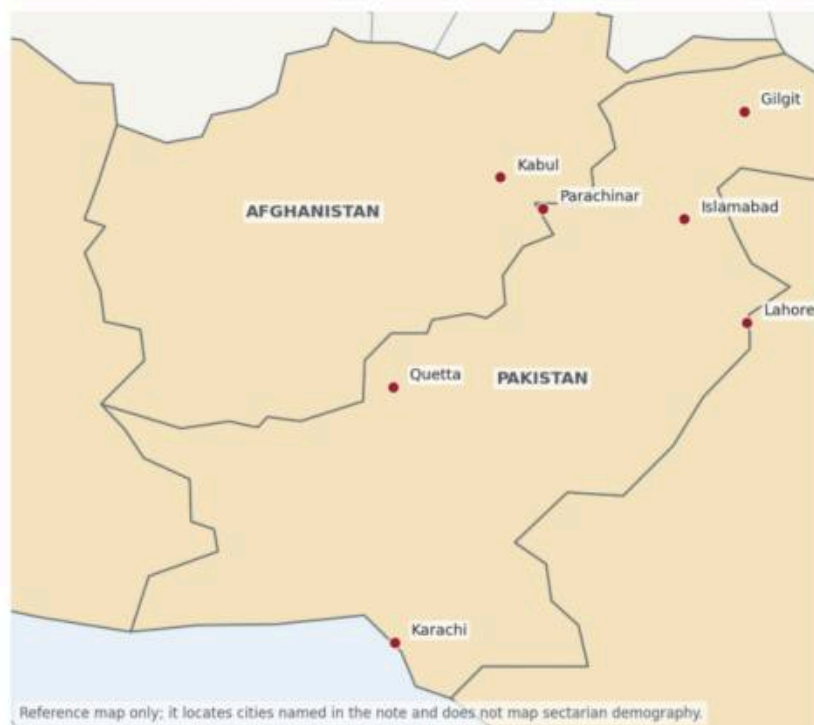
Map: Multipolar proxy-war pattern: Syria, Libya, Yemen and Afghanistan

Source: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

- **The 60-day follow-on negotiation window** under the Islamabad Memorandum is running through the second half of 2026, covering the hardest unresolved issues - Iran's uranium stockpile mechanism, its missile programme, and the future of its regional militia network. Outcomes here will determine whether the 2026 war's resolution holds or unravels.

- **Pakistan's twin-front exposure** - the Afghanistan war and its Iran-mediation role - continues to generate debate over whether Islamabad can sustain both simultaneously without strategic overstretch.
- **India's posture as a deliberate non-mediator**, captured in FM Jaishankar's "not a dalal nation" remark, has become a live comparative talking point in South Asian strategic commentary, contrasting India's caution with Pakistan's proactive brokerage.
- **Reconstruction economics**: the proposed \$300 billion Iran development fund, contingent on a final deal, illustrates how post-conflict economic packages are increasingly built into ceasefire frameworks themselves, not negotiated afterward.
- **Sectarian risk management**: Pakistan's handling of Shia community reaction to Khamenei's killing offers a live template for how multi-sect Muslim-majority states manage external shocks to domestic religious cohesion.

Pakistan domestic sensitivity geography: cities and border context



Map: Pakistan domestic sensitivity geography: cities and border context

Source: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

CONTEMPORARY RELEVANCE | Linking to the Broader CSS Syllabus

This topic connects directly to standing CSS themes: the changing nature of warfare (Current Affairs), Pakistan's evolving foreign policy doctrine (Pakistan Affairs), the role of the military in diplomacy (Governance), and middle-power theory in international relations (Political Science / IR). Candidates should treat the 2026 Pakistan–US–Iran case as the connective thread across all four.

Section 13: Tackling Proxy Wars - The Way Forward

Proxy wars are deeply embedded in geopolitical rivalry and are rarely “prevented” in the strict sense. However, multi-pronged strategies can reduce their impact, build national resilience, and raise the cost of intervention for foreign patrons.

QUOTATION

“No state can fight a proxy war alone - it needs regional consensus and internal legitimacy.”
- Lt. Gen. (R) Amjad Shoaib, Defence Analyst, Pakistan

A. Strengthen State Institutions

Weak, fractured states are the easiest battlegrounds for proxy wars. A strong, professional security and justice system reduces these vulnerabilities.

- Enhance training, equipment, and intelligence-sharing among police, military, and intelligence agencies
- Reform the judiciary to deal swiftly with sedition, terrorism, and financial crimes
- Develop local government systems to improve service delivery in conflict-prone areas

QUOTATION

“Security vacuums invite foreign interference ... strength at home is the first deterrent abroad.” - International Crisis Group, “Pakistan: Countering Militancy in FATA,” 2009

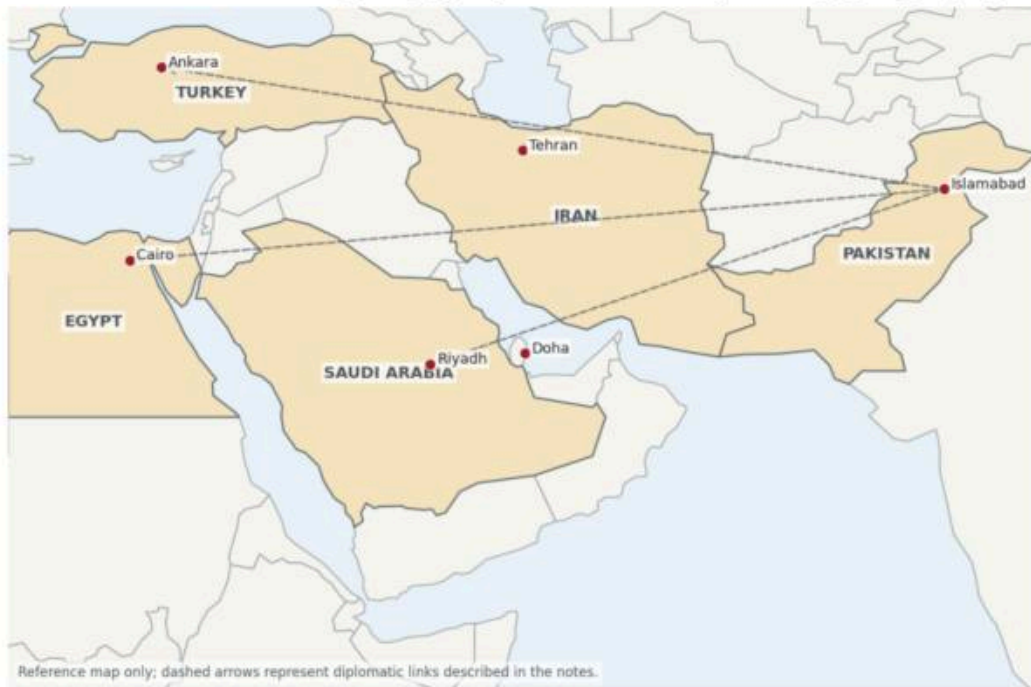
B. Regional Diplomatic Engagement

Many proxy wars arise from unresolved regional rivalries; diplomacy among neighbouring states is essential to defuse long-term hostilities.

- Revive platforms such as SAARC, the SCO, and the OIC
- Establish border-security commissions and conflict-resolution units to monitor cross-border insurgent activity
- Promote confidence-building measures - joint anti-terror drills, shared intelligence hubs

Pakistan's 2026 quadrilateral diplomatic track with Saudi Arabia, Turkiye, and Egypt - convened repeatedly in Islamabad during the Iran-mediation effort - is itself a live example of this strategy in action, and offers a template for future regional crisis-management coordination.

Pakistan-Saudi-Turkiye-Egypt quadrilateral diplomacy geography



Map: Pakistan-Saudi-Turkiye-Egypt quadrilateral diplomacy geography
 Source: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

QUOTATION

"Diplomacy in regional circles is a more effective firewall against proxy wars than global condemnations." - Barnett R. Rubin, "The Fragmentation of Afghanistan," 2002

C. Control External Influence

Foreign funding, fake NGOs, intelligence operatives, and covert channels often finance and guide proxy operations; strict regulatory mechanisms must monitor, trace, and disrupt such flows.

- Register and vet all foreign-funded NGOs, think tanks, and academic partnerships
- Enforce laws requiring declaration of foreign assets and donations
- Create national task forces to monitor digital propaganda, shell companies, and intelligence handlers
- Implement FATF-style financial-tracking systems to trace terror financing and money laundering

QUOTATION

"The flow of funds determines the flow of violence. Transparency is non-negotiable." - FATF, "Terrorist Financing Risk Assessment Guidance," 2019

D. Media and Narrative Management

Modern proxy warfare includes narrative manipulation through social media, news, and academic forums; countering this requires proactive strategic communication rooted in facts and development narratives.

- Establish state narrative cells to identify and debunk fake news and separatist messaging
- Promote civic education and inclusive nationalism that respects ethnic diversity
- Invest in development and media outreach in underrepresented or conflict-prone regions

QUOTATION

"Wars today are fought as much in the mind as on the battlefield." - Clausewitz, *On War* - modern interpretations

E. International Legal Measures

Legal forums such as the UN, the International Court of Justice, and the FATF can be used to expose states supporting proxies, raise reputational costs, and demand accountability.

- Submit evidence of proxy involvement (weapons origin, intercepted communications) to UN panels
- Push for UN Security Council debate on regional destabilisation caused by proxy actions
- Use the ICJ for violations of sovereignty, especially where aggression is state-sponsored
- Encourage FATF to expand monitoring of state-linked financial networks involved in proxy wars

QUOTATION

"Legal exposure is the slowest, but surest way to raise the cost of covert warfare." - Harold Hongju Koh, "International Law in the Age of Surveillance," 2017

F. Lessons From Pakistan's 2026 Broker-State Experience

- **Institutionalise, don't personalise:** Pakistan should convert the Trump–Munir-era diplomatic opening into durable institutional channels - trade agreements, standing dialogue mechanisms - rather than relying on individual leader rapport.
- **Resolve the western front:** sustained mediating credibility abroad is undermined if Pakistan cannot simultaneously demonstrate a credible, rights-respecting resolution to its own Afghanistan conflict.
- **Build strategic reserves:** the 2026 energy-austerity measures exposed Pakistan's lack of strategic fuel reserves; building such reserves would reduce vulnerability to future Hormuz-related shocks.

Pakistan energy exposure: Hormuz, Bab el-Mandeb and Suez approaches



Map: Pakistan energy exposure: Hormuz, Bab el-Mandeb and Suez approaches

Source: U.S. Energy Information Administration, World Oil Transit Chokepoints - https://www.eia.gov/international/analysis/special-topics/world_oil_transit_Chokepoints; base map: Natural Earth public-domain vector map data - <https://www.naturalearthdata.com/>

- **Manage sectarian risk proactively:** continued, structured engagement with Shia community leadership (rather than reactive crisis messaging) would better insulate domestic cohesion from future regional shocks.

Summary Table: Multi-Pronged Strategy to Tackle Proxy Wars

Strategy	Goal	Mechanism
Strengthen state institutions	End internal vulnerabilities	Reform police, judiciary, intelligence
Regional diplomacy	Prevent foreign-state hostility	SAARC, SCO, bilateral border pacts
Control external influence	Disrupt funding and foreign command	Monitor NGOs, trace terror finance
Narrative management	Counter internal and foreign propaganda	Media cells, civic education, development
International legal measures	Build global pressure and accountability	UN, ICJ, FATF evidence submission
Institutionalise broker diplomacy	Convert personal rapport into durable gain	Trade pacts, standing dialogue mechanisms

Section 14: Applied CSS Exam Questions

The following applied questions reflect the FPSC's continuing shift toward analytical, scenario-based questioning rather than pure recall. Each includes a brief note on examiner intent.

Q1. Define a proxy war and explain, with reference to Andrew Mumford's four-part criteria, why not every internal conflict with foreign sympathy qualifies as one.

Examiner intent: tests conceptual precision and the ability to apply a theoretical test rather than use the term loosely.

Q2. "Proxy wars are won tactically but often lost strategically." Discuss with reference to the Afghan jihad of the 1980s.

Examiner intent: tests critical analysis and awareness of the "boomerang effect" - blowback from a tactically successful proxy campaign.

Q3. Examine Pakistan's transition from being analysed primarily as a proxy-war battleground to being recognised as a broker-state in the 2026 US–Iran conflict. Is this transition structural or transactional?

Examiner intent: directly tests the master case study in Section 8 and requires a balanced argument rather than a one-sided celebratory account.

Q4. Critically evaluate the key provisions of the Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding (17 June 2026) and assess whether it represents a durable resolution to the US–Iran conflict.

Examiner intent: tests factual command of the 14-point framework and the analytical ability to separate resolved issues from deferred ones.

Q5. "Pakistan's domestic sectarian composition is as important to its foreign policy choices as its strategic alliances." Discuss with reference to Pakistan's posture during the 2026 Iran war.

Examiner intent: tests the ability to connect social/demographic factors with foreign-policy analysis - a frequently underused angle in student answers.

Q6. To what extent do allegations of Indian and Afghan support for the TTP and BLA meet the requisite criteria of a proxy war? Discuss the evidentiary gap between official allegation and independent verification.

Examiner intent: tests intellectual honesty and the ability to distinguish verified fact from contested official narrative - a key examiner expectation in Pakistan Affairs.

Q7. Compare Pakistan's proactive mediating diplomacy with India's more cautious posture during the 2026 Iran crisis. What does this contrast reveal about competing models of middle-power foreign policy?

Examiner intent: tests comparative analytical skill and awareness of South Asian strategic competition beyond the conventional India–Pakistan security lens.

Q8. Analyse the twin-front strategic dilemma faced by Pakistan in early 2026, balancing Operation Ghazab lil-Haq against Afghanistan with its mediating role between the United States and Iran.

Examiner intent: tests the ability to integrate security-studies and foreign-policy analysis into a single coherent argument.

Q9. "Economic interdependence, not just security calculation, increasingly drives middle-power diplomatic activism." Evaluate this statement with reference to Pakistan's energy dependence on the Strait of Hormuz.

Examiner intent: tests the economic-relevance dimension and the candidate's ability to move beyond purely security-centric analysis.

Q10. Recommend a policy framework through which Pakistan can convert its 2026 mediating success into durable, institutionalised foreign-policy gains rather than a one-off diplomatic moment.

Examiner intent: tests policy-recommendation skills and forward-looking analytical writing, rewarded heavily in the Way Forward portion of CSS answers.

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